

JOURNEYS TO TREASURY

2025/26

10TH ANNIVERSARY EDITION



**EACT SURVEY 2025 | THE FUTURE OF PAYMENTS
PREPARING FOR VOP | VIRTUAL ACCOUNTS AND THE RACE
FOR REAL-TIME LIQUIDITY | AI'S TREASURY MOMENT
+ CASE STUDIES FROM VODAFONE, DEME, EVONIK, COMCAST,
NORSK HYDRO, ACCEL GROUP, ZOETIS**



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CONTENTS +

2**00**

From Fundamentals
to Frontiers

4**01**

Assembling the Building
Blocks for Change

9**CS02**

Dialling Up Cash Flow
at Vodafone

13**CS03**

From Complexity to Clarity:
DEME's Evolving Treasury
Journey

17**CS04**

Treasury Automation in
Action at Evonik

21**05**

The Future of Payments:
Navigating Complexity,
Unlocking Opportunity

27**CS06**

Banking on Change:
Inside Comcast's
Treasury Transformation

32**CS07**

Tackling Practical Questions
in Verification of Payee's
Rollout

35**08**

Verification of Payee:
A Necessary Step Forward in
European Payments

38**09**

Virtual Accounts and
the Race for Real-Time
Liquidity

44**CS10**

Racing the Clock and
Winning! How Accell Group
Built an In-House Bank
in Just Three Months

48**11**

AI's Treasury Moment: From
Hype to Hands On

53**CS12**

Rewiring Treasury at Zoetis

CS : Corporate case study

FROM FUNDAMENTALS TO FRONTIERS

**FOREWORD BY FRANÇOIS MASQUELIER,
CHAIR, EUROPEAN ASSOCIATION OF
CORPORATE TREASURERS (EACT)**

This year marks the tenth edition of **Journeys to Treasury**, representing a full decade of collaboration, reflection, and forward-looking insights. Since its launch in 2016, the project has charted treasury's evolution in aspects such as cash pooling and centralisation, as well as the latest trends in automation, ESG, and AI. Over the years, much has changed. But one constant remains: the need for treasurers to master the fundamentals while preparing for the frontiers that lie ahead.

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The EACT Treasury Survey sets the tone for this edition. Cash flow forecasting has once again risen to the top of treasurers' priorities, alongside renewed attention to systems, data, and skills. These are the building blocks for any transformation. Without them, treasurers cannot hope to take full advantage of the new opportunities presented by technology and regulation.

The corporate case studies featured in this report show how treasurers are applying those fundamentals in practice. At Vodafone, cash flow has become a company-wide mission, influencing decisions across the organisation. DEME illustrates how a treasury can evolve from decentralised beginnings into a mature, centralised partner. Its journey has included tightening controls on bank account openings, embedding sanctions screening earlier in the payment cycle, and transforming long-term loans into sustainability-linked structures.

The benefits of embedding automation at the core of treasury are demonstrated in Evonik's story. It has achieved near-total STP of payments, with real-time dashboards that enhance both compliance and decision-making. Comcast's experience underscores the potential of what can be accomplished through persistence. It began with a fragmented 'Frankenstein' banking landscape. From there, the team set about closing thousands of accounts, reducing its dependence on commercial paper, and building a framework to manage liquidity worldwide. In the process, treasury not only improved visibility and control but also developed new talent and raised its profile across the business.

Transformation under pressure is a theme with which many will be familiar. Accell Group responded to a product recall and excess inventory by designing and implementing an IHB in just three months. At Zoetis, in the years after its spin-off, treasury has been rewired to become lean, digital, and strategically engaged. These stories underline the resilience and creativity that define the profession at its best.

Our pioneering corporate case studies sit alongside roundtable articles that distil the broader shifts every treasurer needs to watch. Payments certainly stand out as a defining theme of this tenth edition. The EU's Instant Payments Regulation is reshaping the landscape, with new obligations arriving this year and beyond. This report is launching in October 2025, the same month that sees the introduction of Verification of Payee (VoP) for PSPs. This name-checking requirement is designed to reduce fraud, but it also raises practical challenges for corporates in areas such as collections and customer relationships. For treasurers, instant settlement presents

real opportunities, whether it's managing liquidity intra-day or accelerating receivables. However, there are also clear risks, particularly in the areas of fraud and integration complexity.

Alongside these changes, ISO 20022 brings its own demands for structured data, while e-invoicing is becoming a core enabler of visibility and automation. Tokenisation and programmable payments may seem further off, but the direction of travel is clear: treasurers must prepare today for a more complex and interconnected payment environment.

Elsewhere, virtual accounts are gaining traction with corporates, offering treasurers the promise of instant visibility if integration and organisational hurdles can be overcome. And of course, AI is moving from hype to reality, with use cases in forecasting, compliance, and workflow automation already being tested in treasury functions.

Taken together, the stories in this report demonstrate how treasurers are strengthening their core competencies while preparing to venture into an exciting future. This has been the mission of Journeys to Treasury for ten years: bringing together perspectives from treasurers, banks, consultants, and technologists to illuminate the path ahead. The partnership between BNP Paribas, the EACT, PwC, and SAP continues to thrive because each brings a distinct and complementary view to the conversation. Here's to the next stage of the journey.



François Masquelier, Chair, European Association of Corporate Treasurers (EACT)

ASSEMBLING THE BUILDING BLOCKS FOR CHANGE

Treasurers are going back to fundamentals, according to the Treasury Survey 2025 from the European Association of Corporate Treasurers. Cash flow forecasting has returned to the top of the agenda, and while digital transformation is a focus, the work begins with systems, data, and skills rather than quick fixes.

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This is shaping up to be a year grounded in essentials for Europe's corporate treasurers. Cash flow forecasting has overtaken long-term funding to become the number one priority in the European Association of Corporate Treasurers' (EACT) Treasury Survey 2025, with almost one in three treasurers (30.5%) prioritising forecasting the most. This reflects a renewed focus on visibility amid volatility and geopolitical uncertainty.

Long-term funding and capital structure remain close behind as corporates shore up liquidity and reassess their balance-sheet resilience. Reviewing and replacing treasury technology infrastructure is now the third-highest priority, a signal that the limitations of legacy tools and architectures are hard to ignore.

EACT Chair, François Masquelier, sets the scene crisply. "In a year marked by macroeconomic volatility, rising interest rates, and global uncertainty, treasury departments across Europe are refocusing on resilience, liquidity visibility, and operational modernisation."

That back-to-basics tone runs through this year's survey. Many treasurers have already centralised payments, automated reporting and built IHBs, yet the leap to the next stage of digitisation is proving harder than expected.

Didier Vandenhaute, Partner, PwC, notes that legacy technology is a key reason why priorities have shifted from innovation to optimisation. "Significant investments have been made in automating and standardising payment processes and reporting, but the perceived value of the next step in digitisation is not always clear. Legacy systems often block adoption of the latest technologies."

These constraints help explain why treasurers are doubling down on core activities, with cash forecasting reclaiming its position as a top priority.

Clarity first: the battle for visibility

The rise of cash forecasting to the top reflects both external uncertainty and internal shortcomings. Many models still rely on semi-manual processes, despite years of investment in automation. The shocks of recent years have exposed the fragility of these processes and reinforced the need for reliable short-term and rolling forecasts. Treasurers recognise that before considering hyper-automation, the basics must be right: systems must work, data must be standardised, and platforms must be consolidated.

Masquelier warns against racing ahead. "You don't want to put the cart before the horse and risk getting lost. It's a bit

"TREASURY DEPARTMENTS ACROSS EUROPE ARE REFOCUSING ON RESILIENCE, LIQUIDITY VISIBILITY, AND OPERATIONAL MODERNISATION."

of a rude awakening for some, as they were expecting to be completely automated, while semi-manual processes are still legion."

Forecasting also sits at the centre of broader priorities. Accurate visibility underpins working capital optimisation, funding strategies, and the ability to manage regulatory and market risk. Yet, the survey shows that 27.3% of treasurers cite inaccurate forecasting as a leading challenge for centralisation, underlining the gap between intent and execution.

Jan Dirk van Beusekom, Head of Strategic Marketing Cash Management and Payments, BNP Paribas, points out: "Working capital management remains a top priority, but it depends on reliable cash flow forecasting."

The dual challenge of clearly seeing liquidity and then acting on it is underscored by the high placement of both forecasting and working capital management in the survey. Treasury's role is central in projects that extend across procurement, sales, finance, and operations, and as such is optimally positioned to help release liquidity within the business. Standard measures include adjusting payment term policies, strengthening SCF programmes, automating receivables, and exploring new collection methods.

Van Beusekom stresses what separates progress from drift: "Working capital enhancement projects are always complex because they include many departments. To be successful requires solid sponsorship from the CFO, clearly identified project managers, and commitment from all stakeholders."

That strategic sponsorship needs to translate into delivery. Treasurers are steering cross-departmental projects while also monitoring the day-to-day flows that determine liquidity strength.

Dr Arif Esa, Global Lead for SAP Treasury and Working Capital Solution, SAP, highlights the operational side: “Effective working capital management ensures adequate cash flow for obligations, while monitoring receivables, payables, and inventory drives efficiency and reduces costs. Done well, it can significantly enhance financial performance.”

Once internal levers are exhausted, attention shifts outward to the funding mix, which remains high on treasurers’ agendas. This reflects persistent refinancing needs and a cautious approach to balance-sheet resilience. Even as rates edge lower, companies are still digesting the costs of the past cycle’s borrowing. With markets prone to bouts of volatility, treasurers are weighing the relative merits of bond issuance and bank financing alongside long-term capital structure choices.

Short-term cash management reflects the same conservatism. More than half of respondents report surplus funds to place in the near term, with most favouring bank deposits and MMFs. Accounts with longer notice and short-term paper feature less, and secured deposits or tri-party repos remain underutilised, despite recent stress in the banking sector.

Laying the digital groundwork

Treasury priorities for cash, working capital, and funding all hinge on the same foundation: technology. Systems shape what treasury teams can see, automate, and control, and the survey shows a strong appetite for upgrades. Reviewing or replacing the TMS ranks ahead of broader digitisation drives, reflecting a pragmatic focus on fixing core infrastructure before chasing the next wave of innovation. Significant investment in payment factories and IHBs since Covid has laid the groundwork, but ageing systems and fragmented architecture are often obstacles.

Vandenhaute reads the apparent decline in treasury digitisation priorities as a reality check, not a retreat. “At first glance, it appears that the digitisation of treasury has declined in priority for treasurers, dropping from fourth to seventh place.” The ranking shift reflects a pause after years of heavy investment and the limitations of existing set-ups. Without clearing those bottlenecks, ambitions for AI, APIs and hyper-automation remain aspirational for now. “Legacy systems need to be revisited if treasurers want to benefit from the latest and most advanced solutions available on the market,” he adds.

The tension between ambition and infrastructure is a recurring theme in the survey. Corporates have spent the past five years building payment factories, centralising



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ENHANCEMENT PROJECTS
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cash and investing in visibility. Still, many now find that their architecture is too rigid to support the next wave of innovation.

Masquelier captures this reality with a metaphor. “A solid foundation is needed, and the implementation of a state-of-the-art TMS tool, or the replacement of old tools, is a kind of prerequisite for hyper-automation.”

For all the buzz around emerging tech, adoption is happening in layers. Interest in data analytics, cloud solutions, and RPA is strong, but AI and blockchain remain lower on the agenda. “The survey highlights a strong interest in technological innovations... however, the lower ranking of AI and blockchain suggests that treasurers are still in the early stages of adopting these more advanced tools,” says van Beusekom.

That gap between established technologies and more advanced ones reflects both caution and pragmatism. Treasurers seek proven tools that reduce manual work today, while also monitoring the potential of AI and automation to transform treasury.

Esa sees automation as central to treasury’s future: “Technological innovations such as advanced analytics and AI provide treasurers with real-time access to financial data, reducing costs and improving risk management.”

And systems are only half the story. Masquelier is blunt about the talent gap. “New tools and the use of AI require new, more appropriate skills. One can’t go without the other.”

That skills gap is one reason treasurers are approaching innovation step by step. The next milestone is clear: real-time visibility. The survey reveals a surge of interest in capabilities that enable teams to react instantly, rather than waiting for end-of-day files. For the next 12 to 24 months, treasurers place real-time reporting, liquidity, and

payments at the top of their technology wish list, a shift that signals both ambition and pragmatism. In industries with fast cash cycles, the ability to act in minutes rather than days is becoming a differentiator.

“Real-time information is no longer a luxury but a necessity for effective cash management,” emphasises van Beusekom.

The point is not speed for its own sake. Real-time capabilities give treasurers the means to base decisions on live data, respond to shocks as they unfold, and demonstrate control to stakeholders.

Esa underscores this perspective from the client side: “Real-time reporting, liquidity, and payments enable treasurers to gain immediate access to financial data, make faster, data-driven decisions, and strengthen stakeholder confidence.”

Momentum is building for the real-time finance environment. Vendors are integrating 24/7 feeds, banks are scaling API-based reporting, and regulations are evolving. This convergence is a pivotal moment for treasury innovation.

“Real-time or on-demand treasury has been discussed in the press for quite some time, but the value is only now becoming truly apparent,” Vandenhoute elaborates. “I expect real-time treasury to become increasingly standard in the coming years.”

Yet progress is uneven. For many treasury teams, the aspiration of instant data still clashes with the reality of fragmented systems and resource constraints. Masquelier observes: “The idea of ‘real-time everywhere’ is present and everyone’s dream goal. Alas, treasurers are sometimes far from where they should be in terms of the immediacy of the information they need to produce.”

Untangling the toughest challenges

Treasurers face as many obstacles as opportunities. Beyond technology, organisational limits are still biting. The survey shows that 38.5% of respondents cite difficulties in standardising processes as their most significant obstacle to centralisation, with budget constraints (30.6%), limited resources (28.8%), and inaccurate forecasting (27.3%) close behind. Fragmented banking relationships and scattered platforms add further friction.

Esa underscores the human side of the problem: “Treasurers face hurdles in hiring and retaining talent, while limited staff and budgets remain the main

obstacles to centralisation. Overcoming these requires not only technology but also organisational commitment and support.”

That resourcing challenge compounds the technical ones. Even where teams have the appetite to modernise, fragmented processes and thin budgets can block progress before it begins.

Vandenhoute points to process fragmentation as the most critical roadblock: “Difficulties in standardising processes are the biggest challenge mentioned in the survey.” Securing executive support is another hurdle. “Investing in new projects that are hard to demonstrate quantifiable value is becoming increasingly complicated when seeking CFO approval.”

Crucially, skills and education are part of the solution. Many treasurers admit that technology alone won’t deliver transformation unless matched with the right expertise. This gap remains difficult to close in today’s talent market.

External pressures compound these challenges, with treasurers handling significant regulatory pressures. ESG reporting (38.7%) and ISO 20022 (33.5%) top the watch list here, followed by the European Market Infrastructure Regulation (EMIR), the Markets in Financial Instruments Directive (MiFID), PSD2, and capital rules. Masquelier stresses the need for vigilance. “The number of financial regulations under consideration or review currently is incredibly high... it is important to make the voice of treasurers heard in Brussels and defend our interests.”

Market volatility is firmly back on the radar, complicating matters for treasurers. After a brief lull in 2023, FX risk has re-emerged as a priority, with treasurers sharpening their focus on exposure identification, policy updates,



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and the case for greater automation in hedging workflows. The survey reveals that more than a quarter of respondents cite market volatility as a key area of concern, indicating that even modest currency swings are prompting teams to reassess their playbooks.

Sustainability is yet another pressure point, although one with uneven engagement. ESG features prominently in the regulatory agenda, but day-to-day treasury involvement is patchy: nearly one in three treasurers (30.6%) report having no role in their company's ESG strategy, and actions remain concentrated on reducing travel and implementing process changes rather than influencing financing or investment decisions. Green bonds and sustainable investments sit much lower on the adoption curve. The survey reveals that 38.7% of treasurers identify ESG reporting as their top regulatory concern, making compliance currently the primary driver of ESG engagement.

Cyber risk adds another layer of complexity. The pandemic-era surge in attacks exposed how fragmentation weakens defences. Esa links fraud prevention to transformation itself: "A comprehensive strategy that combines real-time monitoring, automated controls, advanced analytics, and system integration can significantly strengthen defences against fraud."

More than a quarter of treasurers (27.6%) list fraud prevention as a priority. "The increasing risk of fraud... has made cyber-security and fraud mitigation a critical area of focus," says van Beusekom. "Treasurers are investing in technologies that can provide real-time monitoring and automated controls to mitigate these risks."

The need for patience, practicality, and vision

The survey's overall message is clear: treasurers are pragmatic but not standing still. Priorities for cash, funding, forecasting, and risk management demonstrate a profession rooted in operational fundamentals. Yet, the momentum surrounding real-time data, automation, and selective AI use suggests a quiet transformation already underway. The challenge lies not in ambition, but in sequencing the building of foundations, layering technology, and evolving skills at a pace that organisations can absorb.

Masquelier captures the strain of this balancing act. "The challenge for treasurers comes not so much from the changes themselves but from managing the continuum of changes and the co-occurrence and simultaneity of problems on the economic, financial, and regulatory sides."



"THE CHALLENGE FOR TREASURERS COMES NOT SO MUCH FROM THE CHANGES THEMSELVES BUT FROM MANAGING THE CONTINUUM OF CHANGES."

The tension between treasury's stabilising role and its drive for innovation has rarely been more evident. Teams are expected to anticipate funding needs and market risks while simultaneously driving digitisation agendas. The survey reflects this dual identity: while nearly 40% of treasurers cite process standardisation as a pressing challenge, interest in advanced analytics, real-time reporting and robotics is surging. Balancing these demands requires both patience and strategic clarity.

Despite this, van Beusekom sees reason for confidence: "The EACT Survey 2025 paints a picture of a treasury function that is increasingly focused on real-time data, technological innovation, and risk management. While there are significant challenges, particularly around resources and regulatory compliance, the survey indicates a strong commitment to driving forward digital transformation and improving working capital management."

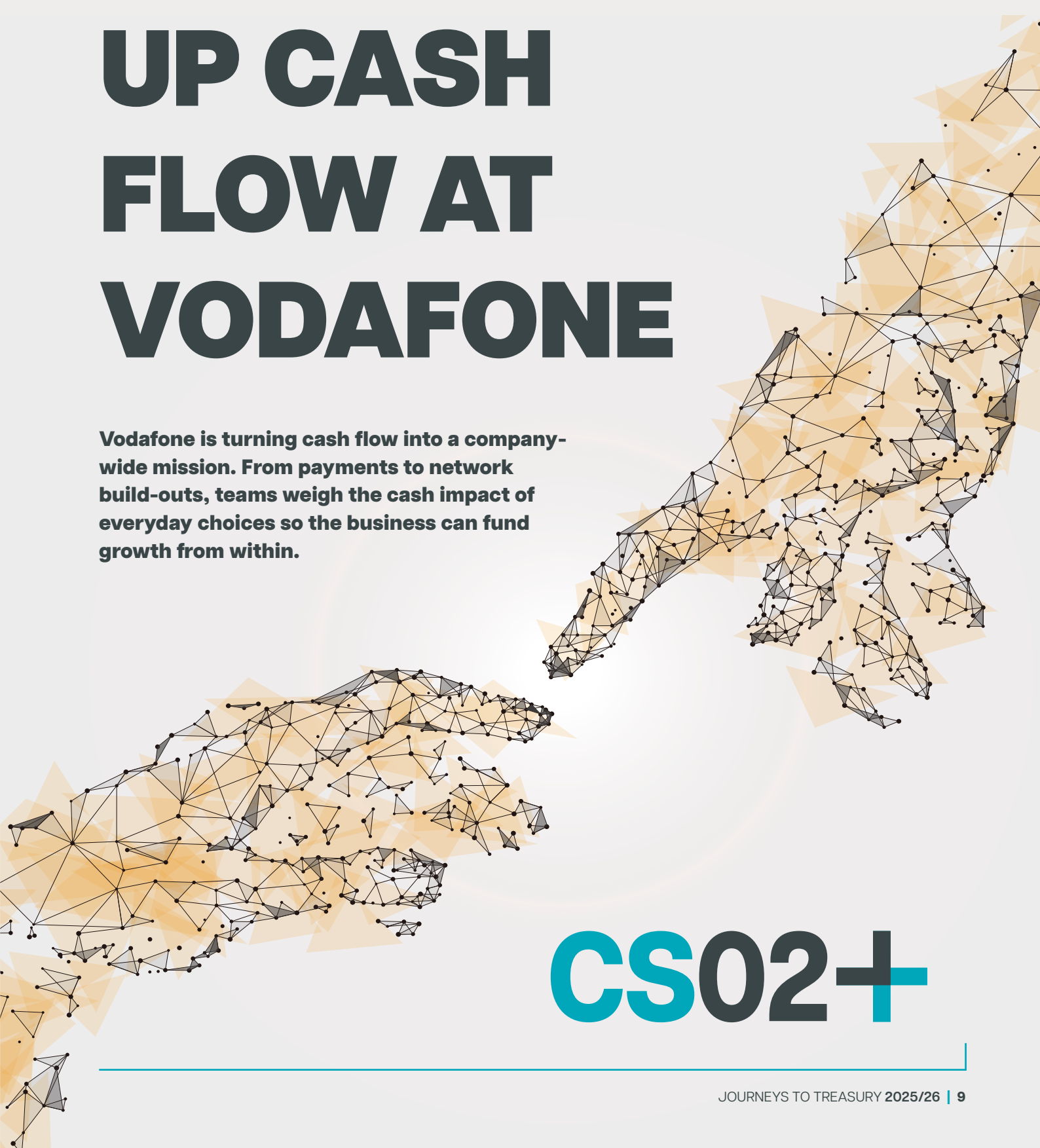
The intent is clear, even if the path is incremental. Treasury leaders are focusing their energy on projects that unlock long-term value thoughtfully and practically.

Vandenhaute's advice reflects this mindset. "If corporate treasury teams want to be able to standardise their processes further, they will first need to collect all relevant information about their current set-up and understand the true costs incurred due to this fragmented environment. Then, they should build a solid business case for change, demonstrating the value of rationalising their banking landscape and IT infrastructure, and finally, secure CFO and CIO buy-in."

For treasurers, the future will be defined less by headline technologies and more by their ability to assemble the building blocks for sustainable transformation.

DIALLING UP CASH FLOW AT VODAFONE

Vodafone is turning cash flow into a company-wide mission. From payments to network build-outs, teams weigh the cash impact of everyday choices so the business can fund growth from within.



CS02+

Telecoms giant Vodafone has been rewriting how it operates, invests, and serves its customers. Cash flow, long considered the responsibility of finance alone, now influences decisions across the entire business.

Maurice Schrijnemakers, Cash Flow Transformation Executive, Vodafone, is direct about why that matters: “If you have a healthy cash flow, you generate cash to reinvest, and reinvestment in the business means commercial success if you do that properly. We aim to increase cash flow in a structural, sustainable way to improve commercial performance, facilitate growth and, ideally, increase shareholder returns.”

Although initiated by finance, it has been adopted across the business as a cultural change, with all functions encouraged to take ownership of their role in cash generation.

As Guido Goeltzer, Cash Flow Transformation Lead, Vodafone, points out: “All functions, including sales, marketing, and networks, are involved in embedding a mindset across the organisation. We encourage ownership of cash flow in day-to-day operations and ensure it’s part of every decision.”

That mindset shift is decisive, but it makes sense only when underpinned by a clear understanding of how cash moves through the business.

From profit to cash

One of the early challenges at Vodafone has been to reframe how people think about the relationship between profit and cash. A healthy P&L statement does not automatically guarantee liquidity. A P&L shows profitability, a balance sheet captures assets and liabilities, and a cash flow statement reconciles the two, revealing the timing and reality of cash movements.

Fixed assets, such as network infrastructure, generate revenue over time, while current assets, such as stock and receivables, can hold cash in place. Understanding how these pieces fit together is vital to knowing where cash is created or absorbed.

In practice, operational discipline makes the difference between headline profit and cashflow. Goeltzer highlights two key measures: days sales outstanding (DSO) and days inventory outstanding (DIO). “These are not only financial figures. DSO is a reflection of operational effectiveness and how quickly a company can collect from customers. With DIO, it’s about the speed of the inventory turnaround.

Both show how effectively the business converts activity into cash.”

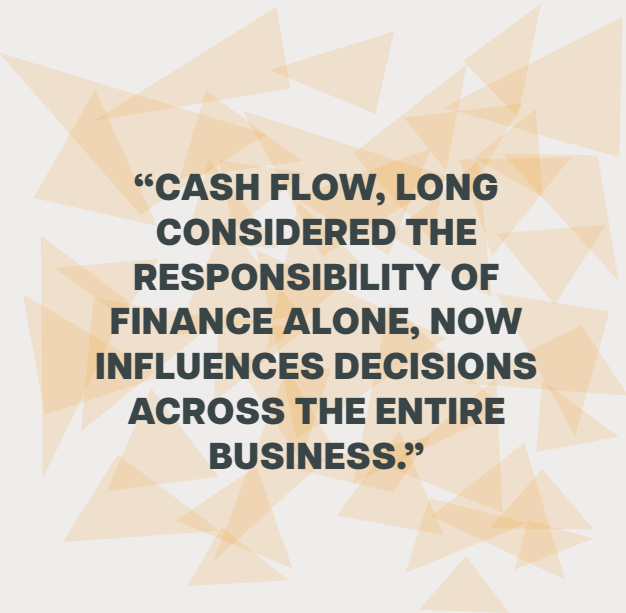
Putting it this way has helped shift thinking across the organisation. Schrijnemakers recalls that before the programme, “cash flow was a topic for finance to manage. With this programme, the business is also accountable. That joint accountability between finance and business starts to pay off simply through awareness in everything we are doing.”

Small moves add up

The cultural change is most visible in the everyday decisions now viewed through a cash lens. In retail outlets, staff encourage customers to set up direct debits to ensure faster and more convenient payments. Account managers include payment terms in their negotiations with enterprise clients. Customer service teams work to resolve billing queries promptly and enhance bill transparency, ensuring customers pay on time or earlier.

On their own, these are small moves, but across all markets, they add up. “Wherever anyone is in the company, they can have a positive impact,” Schrijnemakers stresses. “That awareness is what moves the numbers.”

Finance teams have also embedded working capital impacts into business cases. For example, promotional campaigns now factor in how much stock is bought in advance, and whether assumptions are too optimistic or too cautious, both of which can create working capital challenges. As Schrijnemakers puts it: “Simply having that conversation has a positive impact on performance and cash flow.”



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Data that prompts action

To embed these shifts, Vodafone has introduced practical tools that make cash flow impacts visible in real time. One example is a suite of receivables dashboards, developed in partnership with business units. The process has generated some unexpected enthusiasm, as Schrijnemakers found that the units were requesting additional views and breakdowns while creating the dashboards.

“They came to us with specific requests for what they wanted to see, even things I hadn’t thought about,” he reveals. “Increasing transparency on a customer-by-customer level is driving positive developments. And that transparency also highlights customer issues early, enabling us to resolve them, which creates happy customers and, in turn, improves business performance. It’s a win-win.”

The excitement is not limited to the operational teams. Goeltzer notes that these granular views, combined with senior-level oversight, create a healthy feedback loop. “Cash flow and working capital is a standing agenda point in senior management discussions, while teams on the ground have the data to answer questions going up the chain. That’s where top-down and bottom-up meet.”

Two tracks, one goal

Vodafone has shaped the transformation around two core workstreams, creating a simple structure that enables the company to focus its efforts and maximise impact.

The first workstream, working capital and cash flow performance, focuses on unlocking cash through optimised collections, stock levels, payables, and assets under construction. In a telecoms context, the latter is significant: network build-outs require large amounts of capital before they will generate revenue. Optimising processes to reduce the time assets spend under construction frees up capital for reinvestment.

The second workstream covers reporting, forecasting, and cultural change. This includes making working capital transparent at the business unit level, alongside P&L performance, so teams are accountable for their contribution to cash flow. “The more granular the insight, the better we can plan,” emphasises Schrijnemakers. “We’re improving planning models for cash flow to have much better accuracy, almost daily.”

Forecasting improvements is not just a technical exercise; it enables better conversations. When business leaders

can visualise the working capital impact of their activities in the same way they view revenues and costs, cash flow transitions from an abstract financial concept to a tangible operational goal.

Keeping the programme moving

While the workstreams are operational, the programme’s governance ensures it remains strategically aligned. The initiative was initiated and is sponsored by Vodafone’s Group CFO, and reports directly to him.

The effort spans all finance functions and relies on collaboration from across the business, including financial planning, reporting, supply chain management, data and analytics, shared services, as well as treasury. “It’s not just about treasury,” affirms Goeltzer. “Everyone in finance has a role to play.”

From the start, the Group Executive Committee backed the plan. Schrijnemakers recalls presenting the plan to the committee, supported by enterprise leadership. Early discussions established the correct principles, such as balancing stock levels to avoid shortages and ensuring ownership and alignment before the programme began.

This alignment enables the constructive resolution of trade-offs between commercial objectives and working capital efficiency. Schrijnemakers reflects: “The support from the Group Executive Committee has been fantastic so far.”

Cash realities in telecoms

Like all telecom operators, Vodafone faces industry-specific cash flow dynamics that shape how it manages working capital. Customer acquisition is capital-intensive: upfront outflows occur well before inflows from subscription payments make the relationship cash-positive. For high-growth operators, this can be a persistent drag on cash conversion.

Accounting treatment also plays a role. Some costs are reflected directly in the P&L and EBITDA, while others are capitalised. But in either case, the cash leaves the business upfront. “When we acquire customers, the first few months have a negative cash flow impact,” says Schrijnemakers. “The challenge is to improve our cash flow conversion through how quickly a customer becomes cash flow positive.”

Device financing is one way Vodafone manages the gap, as Goeltzer outlines: “Up until last year, if a customer bought a subscription with a handset, we financed the

handset and the customer paid it back over 24 months. Now, in several markets, we can also sell handset financing, which has advantages for the customer and us.”

Assets under construction present another challenge. Network upgrades and expansions tie up significant capital until they are implemented and go live. “Capital tied up in projects that haven’t gone live yet doesn’t earn a return,” explains Goeltzer. “If we can accelerate delivery, we free up capital either for additional investment or to use as cash flow. It’s not a standard working capital item, but it’s bound capital, and it’s a big focus for us.”

This principle extends across the business. The unifying goal is to reduce unproductive, bound capital, whether in projects, stock, or receivables, and free those resources to drive growth.

From training to data: enabling the organisation

Behind every process and dashboard lies one essential ingredient. As Schrijnemakers puts it: “Success depends on support from the top, together with alignment from all finance leaders across the organisation.”

Training is another vital pillar. With HR’s support, Vodafone has developed sessions for both finance and business teams to build awareness of the importance of cash flow and how individual roles can influence it. Sessions use real scenarios, such as how a store manager speeds collections, or how an engineer shortens build times, for example.

The aim is to create a mindset where employees act as if the company’s money were their own. “If it were their own money, they would want to have it as quickly as possible and not wait three months,” says Schrijnemakers. “We hope to create that mindset in day-to-day decision-making.”

Goeltzer adds a note for treasury leaders considering a similar journey. “In a treasury function, you already have

a lot on your plate with investments, risk management, liquidity, and bank relationships. That’s already a full-time director’s job,” he acknowledges.

Taking on cash flow as a financial performance driver, Goeltzer explains, shifts the remit into more cross-functional territory and requires resourcing beyond the treasury team.

“And don’t be too hard on yourself,” he adds. “This is a much bigger dragon to slay than the daily demands of treasury, so it deserves the right attention and resources.”

None of this works without clean data. Poorly structured or dispersed data in general and sub-ledgers can impair reporting and decision-making. Addressing this requires foundational work, but the payoff is clear: better insights, greater ownership, and improved operational performance.

Making cash flow transformation sustainable

Vodafone’s cash flow transformation is still a work in progress, but the signs are positive. Awareness is high, engagement is growing, and structural changes in governance and reporting are embedding cash flow into the company’s operations.

The more profound change, however, may be cultural. In shifting from finance-only ownership to collective responsibility, Vodafone has reframed cash flow not as a constraint but as a way to fund growth.

That mindset shift is the foundation for sustained performance. And while the technical levers of working capital, forecasting and capital project acceleration matter, it is the human elements of ownership, collaboration, and discipline that will ultimately unlock cash for growth.

“Once business leaders see how their decisions affect cash, they want to be part of the solution,” concludes Schrijnemakers. “That’s when the culture shifts, and cash becomes everybody’s business.”

**“SUCCESS DEPENDS ON SUPPORT FROM THE TOP,
TOGETHER WITH ALIGNMENT FROM ALL FINANCE LEADERS
ACROSS THE ORGANISATION.”**

FROM COMPLEXITY TO CLARITY

**DEME'S
EVOLVING
TREASURY
JOURNEY**

CS03+

DEME's treasury has evolved from decentralised roots to a strategic, centralised function. This sees the team tackling everything from forecasting blind spots, embedding ESG in financing, and navigating the promise and pitfalls of AI.

When DEME began transforming its treasury operations in 2017, it had a clear objective to create a centralised, robust function that could support a growing and globally active business. Much has already been achieved in that regard.

Geert Wouters, Head of Structured Finance and Treasury, DEME Group, explains: "We have reached a point where we have a mature treasury organisation that is centralised, offering all the treasury functions that a global group like DEME requires."

Much of that maturity has come from streamlining. One of the primary early goals of the transformation was to significantly reduce the number of bank accounts and banking partners. DEME now manages outgoing flows through a central payment factory, an internal hub that consolidates and processes payments across the group. This is vital in improving efficiency, visibility and control. On top of that, sanctions screening was added as a safeguard before the release of payment instructions.

With these strong foundations in place, DEME has been well positioned to continue the transformation across a broad range of treasury activities.

Staying in control as the business grows

As DEME's treasury structure has become increasingly centralised, one of the more persistent challenges has been keeping that framework intact as the business evolves and ensuring local entities don't revert to old banking habits.

"Maintaining consistent practices across the group can be challenging, particularly when local finance teams, with the best intentions, explore banking relationships through personal contacts," Wouters reveals.

Those relationships, well-intentioned or otherwise, can quickly undermine the consistency that central treasury has worked to build. To counteract that possibility, DEME has established strict procedures. For example, no new bank account can be opened without direct CFO approval. Treasury also picks up non-standard activity through monthly closings, where account-level detail is reviewed and reconciled.

Still, detection is only half the battle. "It's about maintaining awareness across the group that this isn't just an admin issue," asserts Wouters. "It's about financial control and reputational risk."

Screening smarter, not later

As with banking governance, DEME's approach to sanctions compliance reflects a broader shift towards structured, anticipatory risk management. As well as enforcing rules, it is about building processes that reduce the chance of issues before they occur.

Sanctions screening is a case in point. It was first introduced as a final safeguard by treasury, positioned just before payment execution. "It was really intended as a gatekeeper," reflects Wouters. "To make sure that we did not send payment instructions to our bank that might involve sanctioned parties."

But as the compliance environment matured, it became clear that more could be accomplished. The treasury team began working more closely with DEME's compliance and procurement teams to embed screening much earlier in the transaction life cycle.



"WE HAVE REACHED A POINT WHERE WE HAVE A MATURE TREASURY ORGANISATION THAT IS CENTRALISED, OFFERING ALL THE TREASURY FUNCTIONS THAT A GLOBAL GROUP LIKE DEME REQUIRES."

“We implemented a procurement platform a few years ago, but leveraging that same platform we have now also installed a certain level of compliance checks at vendor onboarding and at contract signing for existing vendors,” notes Wouters.

By initiating screening earlier in the process—during supplier onboarding and prior to contractual commitments—DEME proactively mitigates risk.

Yet even with this layered approach, treasury has opted not to retire the payment-stage checks. “We could assume that we can let it go as we’re completing the sanctions screening at the beginning of the procurement cycle, but for the moment we decided to keep the sanctions screening on outgoing payments in place,” says Wouters. “There is always a risk that between the vendor onboarding and the outgoing payment, something happens.”

Closing the gap on cash visibility

Even with a stronger grip on controls, treasury still faced a significant blind spot regarding visibility over future liquidity. Until recently, cash flow forecasting was a missing piece in DEME’s otherwise mature treasury set-up. The reason lies in the company’s operating model.

“We are a project-driven company,” Wouters elaborates. “Each project is like a new entity that we put in place, with its own cash needs.”

That complexity makes forecasting difficult to centralise. Each project may have its own funding arrangements, cost structures and disbursement schedules, often evolving on different timelines. “It’s very difficult to consolidate all those cash flow drivers and to make informed decisions based on that,” adds Wouters.

Even so, DEME is now taking deliberate steps to close the gap. The treasury team is designing a six-month rolling forecast, with more granular visibility in the first three months and broader estimates for the remaining period. Forecasting will be refreshed monthly, supported by variance analysis to track deviations from plan.

“We have identified our most important cash flow drivers and have made some design principles,” enthuses Wouters. “We have already looked at some potential tools, trying to leverage the existing DEME IT landscape.”

The next stage of developing the forecasting process is to build a proof of concept. “We will start with a few projects and some other crucial cash flow drivers and see where we get to,” notes Wouters.

Exploring the role of AI

Like many treasury teams, DEME is watching AI with a mix of curiosity and caution. The technology promises to reshape how data is processed and forecasts are generated, but its exact role is still being defined.

“Everybody’s looking at AI in treasury,” acknowledges Wouters. “Obviously, cash flow forecasting is an important use case for AI. But we’re also looking at how we can be more efficient in our day-to-day job, and trying to limit the administrative burden.”

The team is exploring several avenues, from automating document handling to reducing manual effort in areas such as supplier due diligence. One persistent bottleneck is KYC, where DEME still dedicates a full-time role solely to meeting the varying requirements of its banks.

“CASH FLOW FORECASTING IS AN IMPORTANT USE CASE FOR AI. BUT WE’RE ALSO LOOKING AT HOW WE CAN BE MORE EFFICIENT IN OUR DAY-TO-DAY JOB, AND TRYING TO LIMIT THE ADMINISTRATIVE BURDEN.”

"KYC is still a very paper-based process, although we had great hopes in the Swift KYC register and other initiatives," Wouters recalls. "Technology could bring a solution to this."

But for now, DEME is taking a measured approach. The focus is on understanding the boundaries of what is possible and reliable, and where human oversight still matters. Notably, that learning curve is not only technical.

"Getting people on that AI train is a challenge, as it's not easy for everybody to step into those new technological evolutions," Wouters admits.

Sustainably financing the future

While DEME continues to experiment with new technologies, another transformation is already well underway. ESG is no longer a parallel track, it's embedded in the group finances growth, reports to stakeholders, and it defines its long-term direction.

As a Europe-headquartered company, DEME faces growing regulatory obligations around sustainability, including new reporting frameworks and a tightening link between access to finance and demonstrable ESG performance. This is a shift that the company's treasury has fully embraced.

"In 2022, we transformed all our long-term loans into sustainability-linked loans, including two sustainability KPIs," enthuses Wouters. The move formalised a commitment to embed ESG into the company's capital structure.

That alignment is now deepening. Following a major acquisition, DEME is in the process of arranging a new financing package in close partnership with the company's ESG department.

"That financing package being a green loan is a great example of how we view ESG as a critical element within our company," affirms Wouters.

Wouters acknowledges that momentum around ESG has cooled in some quarters, particularly outside Europe. But for DEME, the commitment remains firm.

"We don't want to let go [of ESG], and we definitely have reporting obligations," he notes. "We've done our first CSRD [Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive] reporting on the 2024 financials, and we also want to translate ESG into our financing way of working, which is where the new green loan comes in."



"GETTING PEOPLE ON THAT AI TRAIN IS A CHALLENGE, AS IT'S NOT EASY FOR EVERYBODY TO STEP INTO THOSE NEW TECHNOLOGICAL EVOLUTIONS."

Recasting treasury's role

The transformation under way at DEME is about more than new tools or tighter controls. It's about positioning treasury as a strategic partner that contributes meaningfully to the company's performance, resilience, and growth.

"We should never forget that we are there for the business," Wouters underlines. "We're a supporting service, but we want to support even more."

That support now extends well beyond cash and risk. Treasury is involved in supplier negotiations, customer financing, investment decisions and ESG-linked structuring. The goal is to help shape outcomes, not just report on them.

"I see treasury evolving more to an added-value function to the business, being more proactive and involved earlier in the process," concludes Wouters. "We can think together with the commercial teams about the best hedging strategies and payment schedules, and also look at optimising working capital on the supplier and customer sides. These are definitely areas we are looking into being more involved with earlier in the process."

CS03+

TREASURY AUTOMATION IN ACTION AT EVONIK

Evonik's treasury team has embedded automation at the core of its operations, from near-total payment straight-through processing to real-time liquidity dashboards. With integration, visibility, and control as guiding principles, the team is redefining how digital tools support risk management, compliance, and strategic decision-making.

An abstract graphic featuring a large, stylized number '4' composed of a network of black lines and dots. This '4' is set against a background of numerous overlapping, semi-transparent orange triangles of various sizes. The overall effect is a complex, digital, and geometric pattern.

CS04+

Headquartered in Essen, Germany, speciality chemicals firm Evonik Industries AG creates ingredients that are essential to improving the performance, sustainability, and functionality of products used in everyday life. Its technologies support a broad range of industries, from healthcare to animal nutrition and from mobility to manufacturing, often in ways that remain invisible to the end consumer.

Teodora Terzieva, Head of Treasury and Digitalisation, outlines the firm's scale: "We operate in more than 100 countries with around 32,000 employees. In 2024, we generated revenue of €15.2bn."

Just as Evonik's products can operate behind the scenes to enhance the performance of other materials, its treasury function is quietly driving transformation from within, reshaping itself through automation, integration, and strategic use of data. With a dual remit spanning treasury operations and digitalisation, Terzieva is well placed to lead this transformation.

"On the treasury side, I'm responsible for core front-office activities such as FX and interest rate risk management, as well as global cash management," she reveals. "On the digitalisation side, I focus on innovation, automation, and overseeing IT governance, risk, and compliance."

That combination of responsibilities gives her a front-row seat to assess the opportunities and challenges of modern treasury transformation. It has also shaped her distinctive view on how technology should function within the business.

Tech as a strategic partner

At Evonik, digital tools are not just about efficiency. They're central to how treasury supports the operating businesses.

"My approach to technology in treasury is really about making things smarter, faster, and more transparent," Terzieva enthuses. "I see tech not just as a tool, but as a strategic partner in managing financial risks, optimising liquidity, and aligning with our broader business goals."

That strategic thinking led Evonik to become one of the early adopters of SAP's S/4HANA platform, going live in 2018.

"At the time, we had a clear need to modernise and future-proof our treasury infrastructure," Terzieva reflects. "The move to S/4HANA was an opportunity to unify our systems across Evonik companies, integrate seamlessly

with our operational SAP set-up, and lay the foundation for more advanced automation and analytics."

That shift from fragmented systems to a fully integrated platform marked a step change in daily treasury operations. Before the move to S/4HANA, Evonik's treasury team relied on fragmented systems and manual processes, which made it difficult to gain real-time visibility over cash or risk positions.

"Now, with everything from cash management to risk and from payments to reporting all connected, we have a single source of truth," affirms Terzieva. "That enables faster decision-making, fewer errors, and more time to focus on strategic tasks instead of chasing down data."

The shift didn't just improve access to information. It paved the way for automation across some of treasury's most time-intensive activities.

Efficiency gains where it matters

That integrated set-up has also laid the groundwork for something more impactful: embedded automation across day-to-day treasury processes. While other companies may still be preparing the foundations for automation, Evonik is already seeing it pay off in its routine operations.

"One of the most impactful areas has been FX exposure management," outlines Terzieva. "From identifying currency risk to executing hedges and settling transactions, the entire workflow is now streamlined and largely automated. It's reduced manual effort and improved both speed and accuracy."



"I SEE TECH NOT JUST AS A TOOL, BUT AS A STRATEGIC PARTNER IN MANAGING FINANCIAL RISKS, OPTIMISING LIQUIDITY, AND ALIGNING WITH OUR BROADER BUSINESS GOALS."

Regular tasks now take a fraction of the time they used to. “Month-end closes, especially for hedge accounting, are now completed at the click of a button,” she adds. “We have reliable data and clear workflows, which has freed up a significant amount of time for the team.”

Nowhere is the impact of automation more visible than in payments, where around 99% of Evonik’s flows are now processed automatically.

“Payments are a major focus for us,” Terzieva confirms. “We use two main communication channels with banks, Swift and EBICS [Electronic Banking Internet Communication Standard]. Payment files are generated directly in SAP and routed through our Bank Communication Management module, then sent to our service provider, which handles secure transmission to the banks.”

Standardisation plays a significant role here, too. “We stay aligned with industry standards such as ISO,” reveals Terzieva. “That’s one way in which we maintain consistency and reliability in a high-volume, high-risk area such as payments.”

From data to decisions

With greater standardisation across payment flows, the focus at Evonik has shifted to making smarter use of the data behind them. A major part of that shift is the in-house treasury cockpit: a real-time dashboard interface that offers clear, consolidated insight into the company’s financial position.

Rather than relying on fixed reports or IT-managed tools, the cockpit gives treasury direct control over how data is accessed and interpreted. Built internally and drawing on SAP Analytics Cloud, it connects live to Evonik’s SAP system, ensuring users always work with current data with no redundancy or batch updates.

“The cockpit is designed as a self-service tool,” shares Terzieva. “We don’t need to wait on IT support every time we want to adjust a dashboard or track something new.”

That independence has made the team significantly more agile. Dashboards can be adapted to shifting business needs, new data sources can be integrated quickly, and KPIs can be fine-tuned without triggering a lengthy change process.

“Of course, we still rely on IT as a business partner,” she adds. “But we’re much freer to develop what we need, when we need it.”

The cockpit is structured around practical areas such as financial status, exposure management, bank commitments, and capital markets activity. Treasury teams track a wide range of metrics including net treasury liquidity, the split between trapped and available cash, free credit lines, hedging ratios, and counterparty exposures. These enable the team to monitor funding capacity and liquidity risk in real time.

“It helps us stay on top of the situation and take action if needed,” says Terzieva. “That speed and transparency have become part of how we operate.”

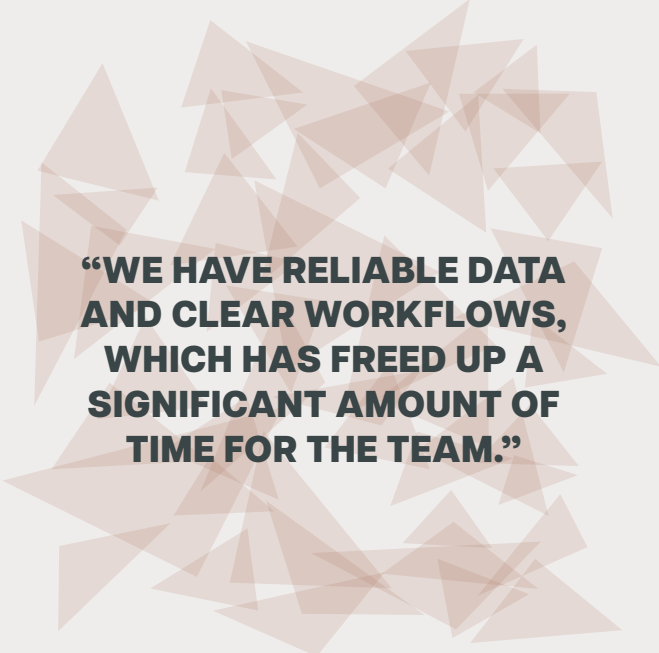
Banking without the baggage

As Evonik has grown internationally, so too has the complexity of its banking landscape. One of treasury’s current priorities is to consolidate banking systems to improve visibility, reduce cost, and simplify processes.

“Over time, we ended up with countless e-banking tools and inconsistent processes,” Terzieva explains. “That made it harder to manage them centrally.”

Some of these systems function as backups to the main SAP platform, but even then, they add risks and create inefficiencies. “We’re aiming to reduce complexity, improve control, and standardise where possible,” she says.

Part of the challenge lies in ensuring consistency across banking partners, when each bank has its own technical set-up, security protocols, and reporting standards. “Maintaining uniform control and visibility is difficult in that environment,” Terzieva concedes.



“WE HAVE RELIABLE DATA AND CLEAR WORKFLOWS, WHICH HAS FREED UP A SIGNIFICANT AMOUNT OF TIME FOR THE TEAM.”

Redundancy and resilience are also key concerns. “You need a reliable backup system for critical processes like payments, but governance is just as important,” asserts Terzieva. “We’re focused on centralising platforms and enforcing consistent access rights, approval workflows, and compliance checks.”

Fraud prevention in a digital age

This focus on strong governance comes at a time when corporates globally are contending with increasingly sophisticated fraud threats. It’s no surprise, then, that prevention is a top priority for treasury.

“No one person can initiate and approve the same payment,” Terzieva points out, thanks to a built-in segregation of duties and approval workflows. “We also use bank account validation tools and regularly update our master data controls to prevent manipulation.”

But controls alone aren’t enough; the human element matters just as much. Education plays a central role in Evonik’s fraud prevention strategy, with regular awareness programmes designed to keep teams alert to phishing, social engineering, and other evolving threats. The goal isn’t just compliance but building a culture of vigilance across treasury.

Evonik also got ahead of the curve on Verification of Payee (VoP), becoming involved well before regulatory pressure on banks and payment providers brought the issue into the spotlight. One of the company’s core banks introduced a technology that enables real-time validation of beneficiary details at the point of payment.

“With a single click, we can send the IBAN and beneficiary name to the bank’s database and obtain a validation result in seconds,” Terzieva says with enthusiasm. “It helps us catch mismatches before a payment is executed, reducing fraud risk, and improving accuracy.”

The long-term goal is to extend this across all regions and banking partners. “We’re in a testing phase to expand global coverage,” she adds. “The potential is there, but not all banks and countries are part of the network yet.”

Scaling what works

With its digital agenda already well underway, Evonik is now focused on deepening integration, expanding automation, and putting their data to more effective use over the next year or so.

“STRONG GOVERNANCE IS ESSENTIAL, AND IT’S IMPORTANT TO REMEMBER THAT THIS ISN’T JUST AN IT IMPLEMENTATION, IT’S YOUR PROJECT AS A TREASURER AND YOU NEED TO OWN IT FROM THE START.”

“We’ve built new workflows for guarantee management using SAP’s Business Technology Platform,” reveals Terzieva. “We’re improving liquidity forecasting and using SAP Fiori apps for more transparent analysis of bank fees.”

Compliance processes are also being automated to improve banks’ onboarding speed and reliability. “We’re automating our KYC [Know Your Customer] process to reduce manual effort and ensure consistent bank onboarding,” she adds.

Reflecting on the transformation journey undertaken so far by Evonik’s treasury team, Terzieva is clear that the people matter just as much as the systems behind it.

“Don’t treat automation as just a technology project,” she urges. “It’s a change management journey. The tools are important, but real success comes from aligning people, processes and mindsets.”

Rather than standing back, she believes treasurers should take the lead, starting with a clear view of their pain points and bringing the team in early.

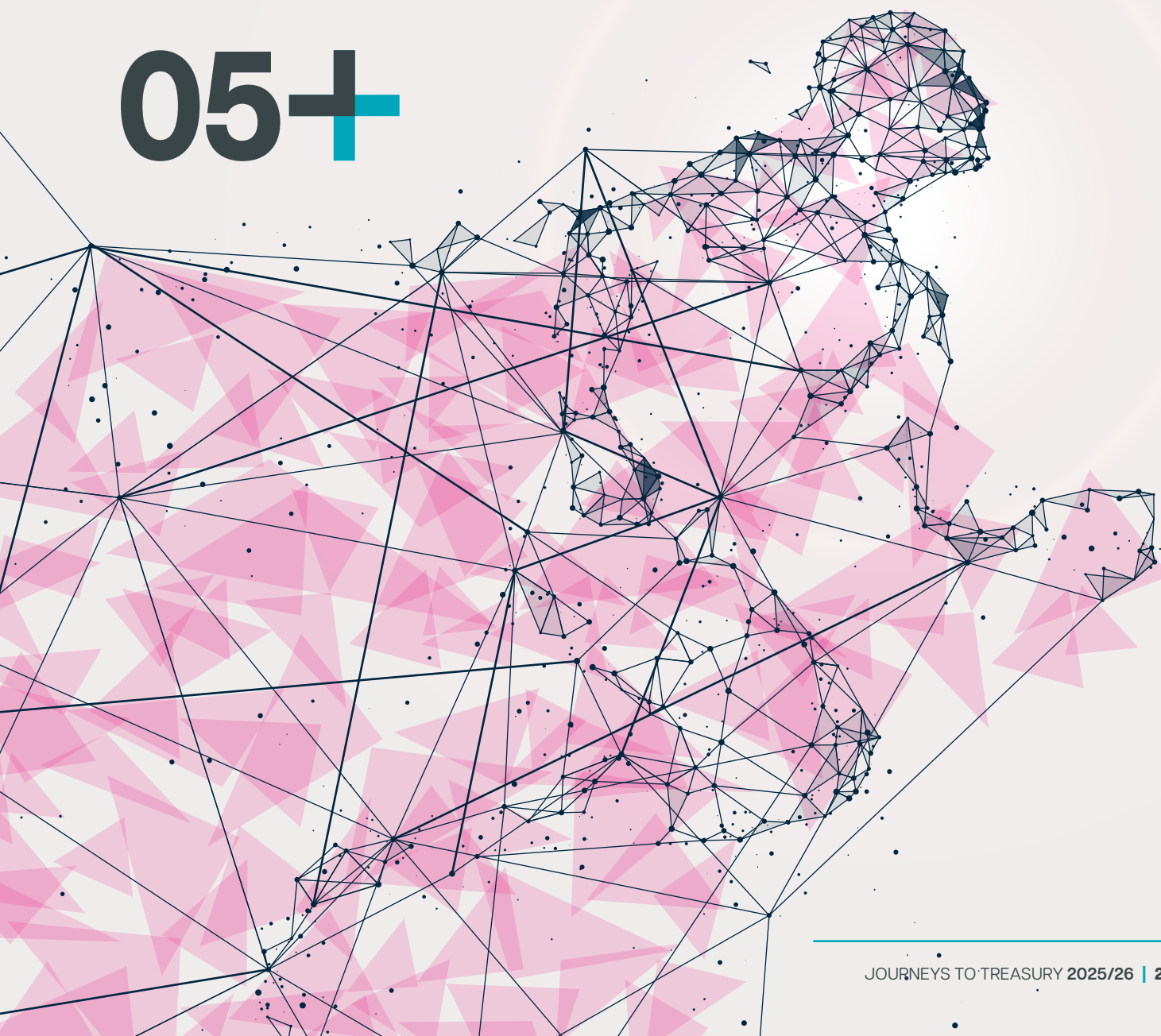
“Strong governance is essential, and it’s important to remember that this isn’t just an IT implementation,” Terzieva concludes. “It’s your project as a treasurer and you need to own it from the start.”

CS04+

THE FUTURE OF PAYMENTS

**NAVIGATING COMPLEXITY,
UNLOCKING OPPORTUNITY**

05+



Incoming and outgoing payments are central to a corporate treasurer's responsibilities because they directly impact liquidity, risk management, and operational efficiency. Today, treasurers face a wave of changes, from instant payments and ISO 20022 to digital currencies and e-invoicing, each of which has implications beyond simple regulatory tick-box exercises.

Treasurers who are prepared for these changes can gain an edge in liquidity management, fraud resilience, and digital readiness. Those who delay, risk losing ground.

With the EU Instant Payments Regulation coming into force, corporate treasurers are weighing the promise and complexity of real-time transactions. While the regulation primarily impacts payment service providers (PSPs), the knock-on effects for corporates will be significant, from new fraud risks and system changes to improved liquidity optimisation.

The regulation came into effect on 8 April 2024, with a first set of obligations for PSPs going live on 9 January 2025. From that date, all PSPs offering standard SEPA credit transfers must also be reachable for instant payments and must offer them at exactly the same price, no higher or lower. The roll-out is already nearing critical mass.

Wim Grosemans, Global Head of Product Management, Payments & Receivables, Cash Management, BNP Paribas, explains: "By now, all European banks and non-bank PSPs should be reachable on instant payments... we're starting to see ubiquity in reachability."

While the regulation is being phased in over several years, one major milestone for corporates to watch is 9 October 2025, when Eurozone banks will be required to send as well as receive instant payments. The final wave, covering European Economic Area (EEA) countries outside the Eurozone, is scheduled for 2027.

While ubiquity is close, some corporates are yet to see the benefits. Adoption among treasurers has been relatively slow, and some practical aspects of instant payments, such as the way bulk payment files are processed, make the benefits less visible in day-to-day treasury operations.

Didier Vandenhoute, Partner, PwC, reveals: "Still today, [instant payments are] not that much used, in the corporate world. Their accounting set-up is based on end-of-day booking, and their payment processes are not always standardised or consistent across their banks." Most treasurers do not operate in real time, and the prospect of unexpected large payments

occurring outside working hours will make some understandably wary.

Fraud also presents a significant concern. In the US, for example, recent data from the Federal Trade Commission showed that in 2024, some \$12.5bn had been lost by consumers because of fraud.¹ Bank transfers are the number one method used to execute these fraudulent payments² some of which is due to the real-time side (number two are crypto currencies while credit cards fall into the number six position).

The European Association of Corporate Treasurers' (EACT) Chair, François Masquelier, points out: "If we want instant payments to be successful in Europe and potentially an alternative to US credit cards, it is vital to ensure the highest levels of fraud protection."

Despite the challenges, the use cases are real and growing for those treasurers ready to act. From real-time claim settlements in the insurance sector to same-moment payroll processing, instant payments unlock tangible efficiency gains. One of the most significant changes in the regulation is the removal of the €100,000 cap on instant payments at the scheme level, which was replaced with a new limit of €1bn minus one cent. This opens the door to a range of liquidity management use cases previously out of reach for corporates.

Vandenhoute notes: "One very obvious [use case is] optimised investment with extended cut-off time and access to funds."

A second use case is the possibility for intrabank, real-time liquidity management. Legacy tools such as Swift MT940 and MT942 messages can be inefficient, leaving treasurers waiting until the next day to finalise positions. This can be a lengthy and painful process. With instant payments, the process can be handled far more efficiently.

"Imagine you can go up to 23 hours, 52 minutes, and centralise the funds between bank A and bank B and still create good value of funds," Vandenhoute enthuses. "Management of intrabank liquidity is becoming much more efficient."

Instant payments are undoubtedly a useful addition to the payment methods available to corporate treasurers, with specific benefits depending on the business model.

Masquelier acknowledges: “Instant payments are certainly a good opportunity, and it’s easy to see certain use cases. For NGOs, for example, every second counts when there has been a catastrophe. And it’s always good to diversify e-payment methods for operating reasons.”

While instant payments operate on a 24/7 basis, the same cannot be said for bank liquidity desks or the underlying funding markets. This disconnect introduces new pressures for banks’ asset and liability management teams, which must manage liquidity in real-time without the full flexibility of traditional funding tools. As banks adapt, corporates also face a learning curve, with the need to understand not only the regulation itself but how these market dynamics might shape the availability and cost of instant services.

Verification of payee: security or stumbling block?

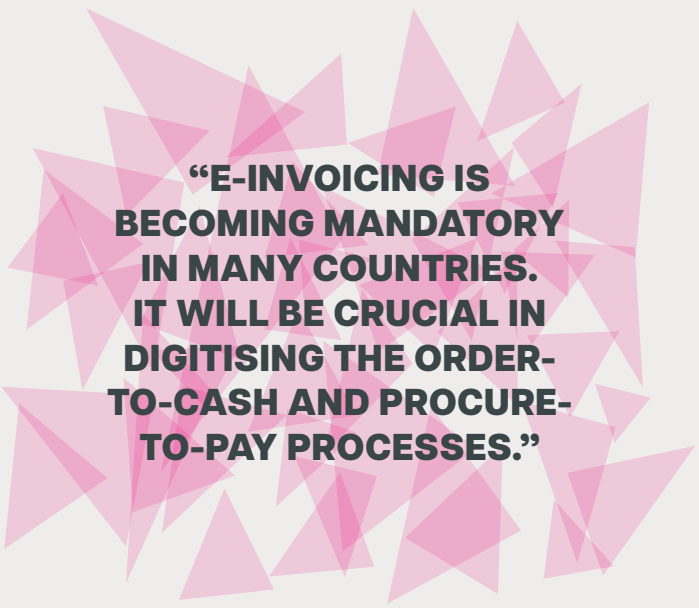
From October 2025, the Instant Payments Regulation will also require a form of account name-checking known as verification of payee (VoP). The goal is to prevent fraud by enabling payers to confirm that the beneficiary name matches the account number on file.

Responses typically fall into three categories: full match, partial match, or no match, and are indicated with green, orange, or red flags. A fourth response, ‘service not available’, may occasionally appear, particularly during the initial rollout.

Grosemans outlines: “We need to educate consumers not to be afraid that, from 9 October, if they get the red or orange light, the payment they are making is automatically a fraud. In the vast majority of the cases, it won’t be.”

The industry’s challenge is to avoid any unintended fallout due to confusion around the regulation. Corporates making collections may see some fear on the payers’ side, especially from consumers who may be rather reluctant to validate the payments. This could disturb the fluency of treasury collections.

VoP may also clash with treasury structures such as collection-on-behalf-of (COBO). With a corporate COBO, the name of the collecting account is, by definition, different to the actual name on the invoice.



“E-INVOICING IS BECOMING MANDATORY IN MANY COUNTRIES. IT WILL BE CRUCIAL IN DIGITISING THE ORDER-TO-CASH AND PROCURE-TO-PAY PROCESSES.”

“We have to ensure that we find smart ways to reap the benefits of VoP without making some kind of Frankenstein’s monster that will make things worse,” urges Grosemans.

Don’t get left behind in the march towards ISO 20022

Instant payments might accelerate speed, but ISO 20022 is all about structure and bringing clarity to the data that powers treasury decisions. Structured data, universal messaging, and standardised fields could help treasurers manage cash more predictably and reduce payment exceptions. However, many are unaware of what they need to do to be ready for the change of messaging format or when to take action.

Vandenhaute warns: “While in theory corporates don’t have to do anything about the ISO transition today, the reality is that if they don’t do anything, they’re going to run into trouble.”

By late 2026, banks must be able to include structured or hybrid addresses in cross-border payments. Without that data held by corporates, many banks say they will reject non-compliant payments. Meanwhile, the support for older formats is at risk of being withdrawn, not by mandate but due to cost.

“Some banks have already mentioned that they are seriously considering stopping support for certain local legacy formats for cross-border payments,” stresses Vandenhaute.

ISO 20022 isn’t just a compliance issue. It’s a strategic upgrade to support everything from legal entity identifiers (LEIs) to improved compliance screening and end-to-

end payment visibility. But treasurers must begin that transition now.

Grosemans points out: “If you don’t start to think ISO native as a corporate, you will survive for now. But in three years’ time, you will run into trouble.”

Accurate, structured information, from addresses and tax IDs to LEIs, will determine how well corporates can take advantage of this new richer payments infrastructure. Crucially, this is not about format for format’s sake. It is about future-proofing payment flows and unlocking straight-through processing (STP).

“It is also vital to do the work on the master data now, as this not only includes the address, but all the other elements too,” adds Grosemans.

While some corporates may assume extensions to the various ISO 20022 deadlines will come, and therefore no action is required on their part for now, that is a risky position to take.

Masquelier underlines: “People might expect that deadlines will be postponed or the transition period will be extended and they can live forever with a double-format approach, but that won’t be the case.”

There are concerns that corporates may underestimate the effort required to transition to the new format, particularly when dealing with multiple systems and counterparties.

“Having affiliates maybe across the world, living with different systems, different solutions... it will be more complicated and complex than we initially thought,” reflects Masquelier.

In that context, asking the right questions of vendors, banks, and advisers is essential, so treasurers know precisely how data will be handled. As with instant payments, treasurers who get up to speed with the incoming changes as soon as possible will have more control, insight, and a better foundation for what comes next.

Where digital currencies fit in

As the payments infrastructure becomes more interconnected, attention also turns to what comes next. Beyond regulations and data standards, the emergence of digital currencies and tokenised instruments signals a more transformative shift in how value might move in future. While current efforts centre on a retail digital euro, a wholesale version is more likely to prove relevant for corporate treasury.

For those charged with planning how the future of money will look, digital currencies are a vital piece of the puzzle. “When you talk to EU civil servants at the [European] Commission, there’s the impression that instant payments and a digital euro will be two fantastic solutions that they expect to create a revolution,” reveals Masquelier.

Despite this enthusiasm, the digital euro is still several years away. The European Central Bank’s (ECB) second progress report on the digital euro, published in December 2024, noted that the bank has updated its scheme rulebook for the currency, aiming to harmonise digital euro payments across the euro area.

The ECB will also shortly publish the providers it has selected for digital euro components and related services on its website this year. And work continues in the form of user research, stakeholder innovation partnerships, and with national central banks and competent authorities on the methodology to calibrate digital euro holding limits.

“This is important because we need to act, compared with other regions in the world, to offer more means of payment to our customers,” notes Masquelier. This is particularly relevant for B2C businesses in Europe, where merchants pay increasing scheme fees for US credit card programmes. “If we want alternatives to US card dominance, we need other solutions, but they will take time to come,” he adds.

In the meantime, market-driven initiatives such as Wero, and similar payment solutions in southern and eastern Europe, are already addressing parts of this challenge by offering low-cost, pan-European B2C payment options.



“WE NEED TO EDUCATE CONSUMERS NOT TO BE AFRAID THAT...IF THEY GET THE RED OR ORANGE LIGHT, THE PAYMENT THEY ARE MAKING IS AUTOMATICALLY A FRAUD. IN THE VAST MAJORITY OF CASES IT WON'T BE.”

Tokenisation and programmable payments

The most promising use cases may come from programmable payments and tokenised instruments. Applied to treasury operations, it could unlock new ways to manage liquidity. Vandenhoute says: “Let’s imagine you have real-time payments and treasury says it is going to zero-balance my funds, but only if payables have been made,” he illustrates. “If not, that payment can be held and rechecked in two hours. You can think about any suspended payment in this regard. There are going to be plenty of use cases.”

For treasurers, the ability to automate high-value payments based on predefined triggers such as regulatory checks, FX settlements, or funding thresholds opens the door to a more agile liquidity environment. This offers the prospect of synchronised, real-time workflows that span systems, counterparties, and even jurisdictions.

Grosemans identifies: “The key issue is how to build payment products that offer atomic settlement and can seamlessly link into financial asset infrastructures like FX, bonds, and trade in a fully automated, round-the-clock way. That’s what programmable payments can help unlock, across both public and private use cases.”

Today, most global treasury operations still depend on batch processing, daylight hours, and end-of-day cut-offs. Programmable payments could entirely sidestep these barriers. Tokenised instruments could enable corporates to execute large-value cross-border transactions any time, reducing their reliance on forecasts and intraday manual interventions.

Recent regulatory developments are also adding momentum. In the US, the Genius Act has now been passed, while Europe’s MiCA regulation is further enabling stablecoin activity. These frameworks are helping

stimulate use cases, particularly in the public space, though private-sector applications may also follow, depending on the ecosystem.

But adoption won’t come without friction. A critical challenge here is complexity, as treasurers may struggle to navigate a fragmented and rapidly evolving world of stablecoins, wholesale central bank digital currencies (CBDCs), and private deposit tokens. Each of these has different characteristics, risks, and legal frameworks. Questions remain over how such instruments would be accessed and whether they would be treated like current accounts or segregated assets.

Perhaps the most likely path forward is the creation of an overlaying connection between large corporates, their liquidity banks and core counterparties. This overlay would run parallel to, rather than replace, existing payment systems. “We believe it’s going to happen in the coming years,” Grosemans notes, “but more as some kind of a superhighway between the most important corporate treasury banks and liquidity hubs.”

At its core, the value of digital currencies for treasury isn’t about reinventing money but rather about solving real, specific problems. Think less mass-market disruption, more precision tools for high-friction scenarios. These instruments aren’t for everyone, but they could be game-changing for the correct use cases. And while it is still early in the adoption curve, the tipping point may be closer than many expect.

“It’s not five-to-ten years away,” asserts Grosemans. “It’s more a question of two to three.”

Keep e-invoicing clear of operational noise

As payments and messaging formats evolve, so do the upstream processes that feed into treasury operations.

“WHILE IN THEORY CORPORATES DON’T HAVE TO DO ANYTHING ABOUT THE ISO TRANSITION TODAY, THE REALITY IS THAT IF THEY DON’T DO ANYTHING, THEY’RE GOING TO RUN INTO TROUBLE.”

E-invoicing, once considered a finance-side issue, is now emerging as a crucial enabler of automation, cash visibility, and working capital optimisation.

Masquelier elaborates: “E-invoicing is becoming mandatory in many countries. It will be crucial in digitising the order-to-cash and procure-to-pay processes.”

While often led by accounting or tax departments, the treasury implications are significant. “It could have a strong impact, bringing more visibility, faster processing, reduced risk, and greater automation in reconciliation,” suggests Masquelier. “It’s one part of the puzzle for treasurers.”

While implementing e-invoicing at the corporate level may seem to be a technology challenge first and foremost, the largest issue faced is often the complexity of the involvement of so many different departments in the process. “We always need a solid sponsorship from the management and the C-suite leaders, but it’s not always considered a top priority by EACT members,” adds Masquelier.

Despite this, the implications for treasury are far from marginal. E-invoicing can enhance receivables visibility, support faster reconciliation, and create opportunities for automation that extend well beyond the finance function. It also lays the groundwork for more efficient payment flows, dynamic discounting, and improved working capital management when integrated effectively.

One example is the ability to attach a payment request directly to an invoice. This streamlines the receivables process and reduces the friction between billing and cash application.

Grosemans underlines: “It stands to reason that an e-invoice with structured data allows for automating the payments and receivables process downstream.”

To grasp possibilities such as this, treasury teams must be positioned as enablers of broader digital transformation. For example, treasurers are ideally placed to show other business partners how invoicing intersects with cash flow strategy and supply chain finance. Success will depend on

cross-functional co-ordination and, crucially, sponsorship from the C-suite to ensure e-invoicing projects don’t get lost in the operational noise.

Strategic priorities for the year ahead

With instant payments, messaging overhauls, digital currencies, and invoicing mandates all accelerating in parallel, it’s easy to understand why many treasurers feel overwhelmed when considering such a dynamic topic. So, where should treasurers’ focus be?

Masquelier suggests: “Pay attention to instant payments, talk with your treasury association, look at the regulation and try to have a roadmap. And talk to your suppliers... the later you start your project, the more complicated it will be.”

Grosemans adds a note of caution: “The priority is not to adopt instant payments... it is about understanding the conditions around it to adopt them.” For treasurers, that means looking beyond speed and assessing how existing controls and infrastructure need to adapt, from fraud monitoring to liquidity planning.

Separately, firms should also assess their readiness for ISO 20022. From master data quality to structured addresses and LEIs, the shift toward richer payment data will shape everything from reporting to straight-through processing. Treasurers are encouraged to ask their banks how best to prepare and where they might benefit.

For Vandenhaute, the message is clear: “For payments, it’s a combination of automation, protection, and then enhancement. If not already there, put in place a centralised, automated payment factory with the right controls and the right dataset behind it. Then, real-time payments can be included in the loop with the right controls behind them, and with all the new elements, there can be significant value added into the corporate payment chain.”

The future of payments is not just instant, it is complex, interconnected and strategic. For treasurers willing to engage now, the payoff could be real-time visibility, stronger control, and smarter decision-making across the board.

Notes

- 1 www.ftc.gov/news-events/news/press-releases/2025/03/new-ftc-data-show-big-jump-reported-losses-fraud-125-billion-2024
- 2 public.tableau.com/app/profile/federal.trade.commission/viz/FraudReports/PaymentContactMethods

BANKING ON CHANGE

INSIDE COMCAST'S TREASURY TRANSFORMATION

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At Comcast, what began as an ambitious clean-up of legacy accounts has evolved into a multi-year transformation that continues to reshape how treasury operates and how it's perceived. The treasury team hasn't just streamlined systems. It has rebuilt trust, unlocked cash, and earned a seat at the strategic table.

When the global media and technology company Comcast first set out to overhaul its global treasury operations, the scale of the problem was hiding in plain sight. Years of acquisitions, including the landmark 2018 purchase of Sky, had left the group with what Bobbie Eiseman, president of Comcast Capital Corporation, memorably describes as a “Frankenstein” banking landscape.

“We had a piece stitched here and another piece bolted on there,” Eiseman elaborates. With around 100 banks and nearly 4,000 accounts worldwide, the result was a fragmented web of legacy providers, regional practices, and pools of idle cash that the corporate parent couldn't access. In some cases, the treasury team lacked even basic visibility of balances across accounts held in remote entities. That fragmentation was not only inefficient, it had financial consequences.

“We were routinely in the commercial paper market, borrowing cash at levels that we had on hand but just couldn't get to,” Eiseman recalls. The business was financing itself externally, even as substantial internal liquidity sat dormant.

From Frankenstein to framework

Comcast's treasury began tackling the sprawl with what would become a multi-year, multi-continent effort to build a unified liquidity framework. The initiative started in Europe, the Middle East, and Africa (EMEA) with the creation of a multinational notional pool. Then it expanded into North America, Latin America, and the Asia-Pacific region.

“Our vision was always to optimise our global liquidity structure,” Eiseman explains. This meant sweeping more cash, more frequently, and using partner banks and automation to enhance control and efficiency.

Over time, the project crystallised into five core tenets, now embedded in Comcast's business-as-usual (BAU) policy. First came a requirement for prior-day balance and statement reporting, ensuring treasury had daily visibility of cash positions worldwide. Next was a push to rationalise banking relationships, consolidating around a

small group of global strategic partners. The third tenet enforced automated pooling and sweep structures, with participation mandatory unless a business case justified an exception.

Technology formed the fourth pillar, with FIS Trax implemented as a centralised payments pipeline and data conduit. Finally, the fifth tenet focused on automation, utilising Trax to deliver statement data directly into ERP systems, generate journal entries, and streamline internal reporting, while ensuring that all exceptions were documented, approved, and time-limited.

The numbers tell the story: more than 2,000 bank accounts closed, an average drop from six accounts per entity to three, and 87% of accounts now consolidated with partner banks. Over 93% of accounts provide automated balance and statement reporting, and more than 80% of on-hand cash is now accessible by the corporate team.

Regional variations, consistent goals

While the global outcomes were striking, getting there required a nuanced, region-by-region approach. Each geography presented its own set of logistical, regulatory, and cultural hurdles, all of which had to be navigated without losing sight of the core objectives.



“OUR VISION WAS ALWAYS TO OPTIMISE OUR GLOBAL LIQUIDITY STRUCTURE.”

In the US, where more than 40% of Comcast's bank accounts still resided, everything from closing old accounts to consolidating new ones had to be meticulously tracked and tested. It was a "huge logistical lift," according to Eiseman, underscoring the need for detailed communication and planning across teams.

Latin America's restrictive banking regulations added another layer of complexity, which was further compounded by language barriers. "We had to provide extra coordination with local teams," Eiseman reveals, as the project navigated both regulatory nuance and multilingual documentation.

Asia-Pacific presented its own fresh set of constraints. Japan's detailed banking documentation requirements, local systems, and time zones tested the team's flexibility. China proved particularly challenging for automation. "We had a lot of exceptions there due to banking regulations and payment systems," notes Eiseman. "But we still try to maintain the critical pieces, like ensuring we have visibility and control over our bank accounts in the region."

Legal, compliance and banking partnerships

These regional variations didn't just affect operations on the ground, they prompted a broader review of legal frameworks and banking relationships. As treasury consolidated its partner banks, it also took the opportunity to examine the foundation on which those relationships were built. "We had long-standing partner banks, and a lot of the agreements had not aged well," reflects Eiseman. "So we brought all of that in line with current standards."

This was more than a documentation tidy-up. Aligning legal frameworks improved consistency

across regions, clarified responsibilities, and ensured compliance with newer rules on data privacy and protection. It also deepened relationships with selected strategic banks, reinforcing expectations and accountability.

This legal clean-up also strengthened Comcast's readiness for future structural changes. When NBCUniversal announced the spin-off of several cable and digital assets, treasury already had full transparency over account ownership, signatory details, services, and balances thanks to the work done during the transformation. By aligning legal documentation with current data protection standards, the team not only met today's regulatory expectations but also laid the groundwork for automation, spin-offs, and other organisational shifts that demand a clean legal and operational baseline.

From liquidity to leverage

With more than 80% of on-hand cash now accessible and over 2,000 bank accounts closed, the transformation clearly delivered on its liquidity goals. One of the most tangible outcomes was a sharp reduction in those costly commercial paper borrowings.

"We were able to nearly eliminate that part of our short-term borrowing," enthuses Eiseman. "And once we layered in that interest avoidance from leveraging on-hand cash versus going out to the commercial paper market, it really supercharged the savings and project ROI."

Even with conservative assumptions on interest savings, using the rates in place during the 2019 approval phase rather than today's higher levels, the cost-benefit analysis showed a payback period of less than one

"WE HAD LONG-STANDING PARTNER BANKS, AND A LOT OF THE AGREEMENTS HAD NOT AGED WELL, SO WE BROUGHT ALL OF THAT IN LINE WITH CURRENT STANDARDS."

year. This marked a turning point in how treasury could manage short-term funding needs using its own resources.

Additional benefits were revealed as the programme matured. Treasury created a scalable, bank-agnostic structure that simplified the connection between internal systems and banks. Legal agreements were updated, and a single connectivity layer eased the path for business units undergoing their own upgrades.

“We had wins in places we didn’t even know would be meaningful,” shares Eiseman. “One of our business units recently did a major ERP upgrade and, because of our project, their accounts were already cleaned up, their payment formats were known, and the bank connectivity was in place. It saved them a lot of time and effort.”

The treasury transformation also prepared Comcast for wider structural changes, as the NBCUniversal spin-offs illustrate.

A proving ground for talent

One of the most underrated benefits of the transformation was its impact on team development. Treasury professionals could take on new responsibilities, demonstrate leadership, and earn recognition.

“We were able to effectively test-drive team members with increased responsibilities and award them with promotions within the teams,” Eiseman points out. Others were spotted by different departments and tapped for special projects outside treasury. Some moved from executional roles into broader strategic positions, helped by the visibility and ownership they gained throughout the programme.

These effects were felt well beyond headquarters. The levelling-up of regional capability marked a shift in how treasury operated globally. As new systems and workflows were embedded, teams across continents assumed more strategic responsibilities, creating a deeper and more resilient talent pool.

The transformation has given staff members room to grow, lifted morale, and brought new visibility to the team’s work. Most importantly, it marked a shift in mindset from delivery to problem-solving.

“There’s more room for critical thinking,” affirms Eiseman. “We’re solving different kinds of problems now.”



**“WE WERE ABLE TO
EFFECTIVELY TEST-
DRIVE TEAM MEMBERS
WITH INCREASED
RESPONSIBILITIES AND
AWARD THEM WITH
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THE TEAMS.”**

The next wave: cloud, data and continuity

Six years on, Comcast is already entering its next upgrade cycle. With early systems now due for replacement, treasury is shifting from server-based to cloud-based environments guided by the same steady, adaptable governance that shaped the original transformation.

Several long-term bank pricing agreements signed early in the transformation are now up for review. With market conditions and service models having evolved since then, treasury is preparing to benchmark existing terms and explore whether current arrangements remain competitive.

The team is also utilising its historical data. Treasury now uses Power BI to reduce its reliance on system-based custom reports and is exploring how historical cash flow information can enhance forecasting. As confidence in the data grows, other departments are starting to show interest in accessing the centralised treasury dashboards to support their own planning and decision-making.

Treasury is applying that same outlook to what comes next, where two priorities stand out. First is a renewed look at virtual accounts, which Comcast set aside during the initial transformation to focus on structural fixes. With systems now stabilised and the landscape shifting, the team is ready to reassess their potential.

The second item is the automation of internal transfers between regional and global liquidity pools. These movements are still managed manually to

accommodate late-day activity, but with more historical data and improved visibility, the risk profile is evolving.

“We now have enough data to determine whether we can safely automate those sweeps without impacting late-day funding requirements,” confirms Eiseman.

Leading with tech and trust

As treasury becomes more digitised, it also becomes more demanding. The skillset required to lead a function like Comcast’s is no longer limited to financial acumen. It now includes technical fluency, cross-functional agility, and the ability to communicate with impact at every level of the business.

“This system has made us the nerve centre for the company’s global payments bank data, and that comes with a lot of responsibility,” underlines Eiseman.

Today’s treasurers must be comfortable navigating complex infrastructures and explaining them with clarity. “It’s no longer enough to read a flow chart or interpret acronyms like SFTP [Secure File Transfer Protocol],” she notes. “You need access to specialised knowledge, and the ability to explain these concepts to anyone, at any level.”

To support that shift, Comcast has invested in a dedicated treasury technology manager and analyst, alongside third-party providers offering 24-hour support to cover Asia-Pacific and EMEA time zones. It’s a recognition that treasury’s operational tempo no longer fits neatly within US working hours or within finance alone.

But with new tools come new pressures. AI, for example, is both an opportunity and a challenge. Treasury teams often compete for limited development resources, especially when automation gains cannot be tied directly to headcount reductions. Yet the potential is clear.

“There are efficiencies to be gained with AI, but it still requires human judgement, and a lot of the use cases need proper review and vetting,” Eiseman comments. She sees potential value in applications like KYC checks and data validation workflows, where speed and consistency can improve without compromising oversight.

Where instinct still leads

No matter how advanced the systems become, certain human capabilities remain essential. “Even with all the

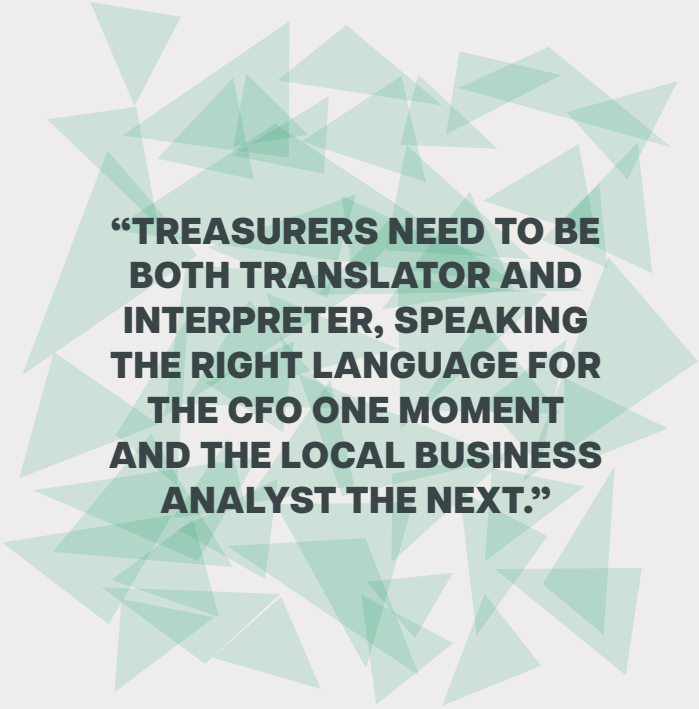
technology advances, some things are not going to go away,” assures Eiseman. “There will be perennial issues that require human thought, human intervention and emotional intelligence.”

Communication, in particular, remains central both as a tactical necessity and as a leadership discipline. “Treasurers need to be both translator and interpreter, speaking the right language for the CFO one moment and the local business analyst the next,” she adds.

Comcast’s approach to communication during the transformation reflected that principle. A senior steering committee provided strategic direction, while operational committees helped cascade updates, surface issues and coordinate delivery. Once alignment was secured, detailed workstream conversations followed.

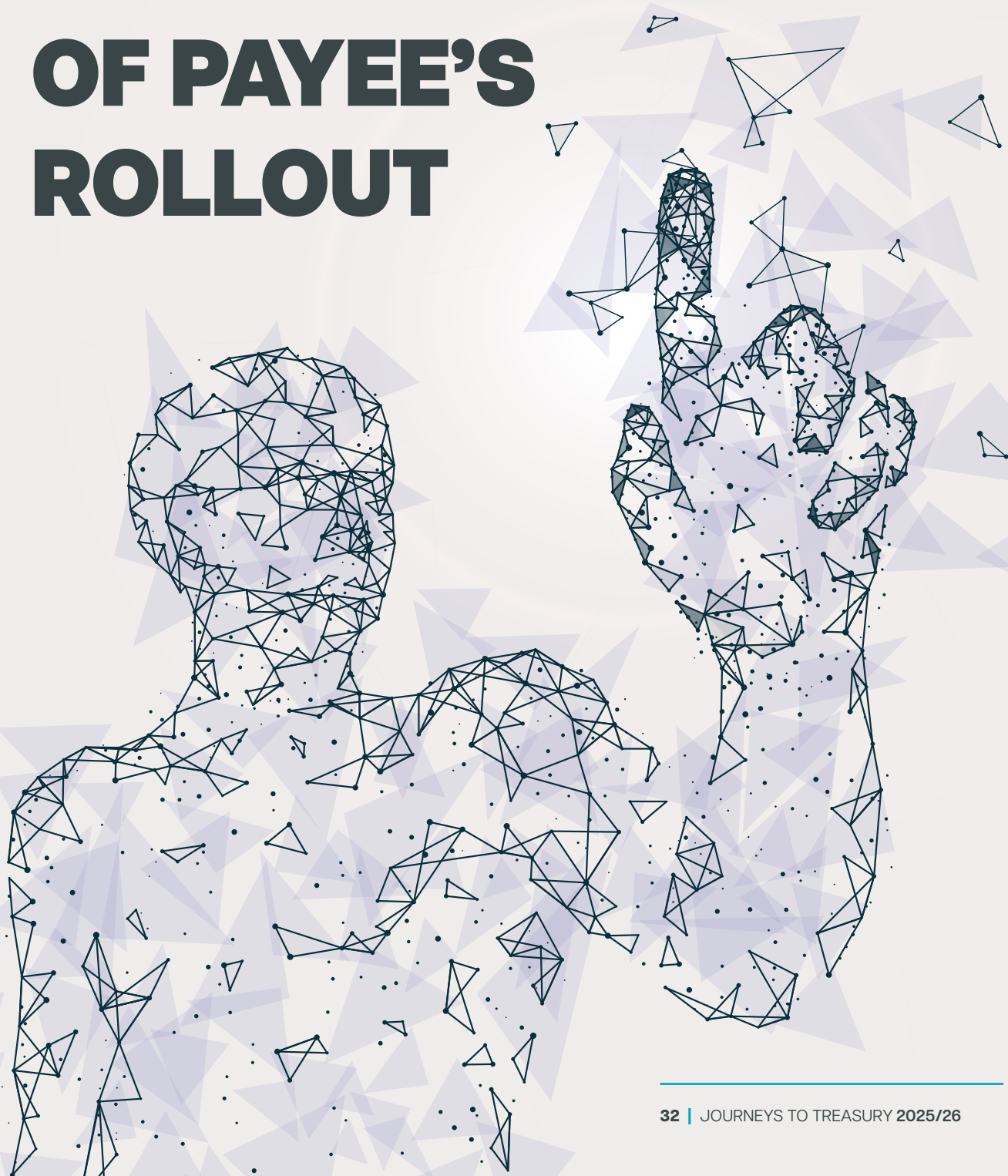
The structure helped the team maintain focus through each wave of change. While other organisations may prefer a lighter model, the core idea holds true: transformation lives or dies on clear roles, shared context and deliberate engagement. And for treasurers looking to lead from the centre, those are skills every bit as vital as technical know-how.

As Eiseman reflects on the future of the profession, her message is clear: “In the end, I see a more automated treasury profession, but also a continual evolution in the skills we humans need to keep developing – for ourselves and our teams to stay successful.” It’s a vision that Comcast’s treasury team is already bringing to life.



“TREASURERS NEED TO BE BOTH TRANSLATOR AND INTERPRETER, SPEAKING THE RIGHT LANGUAGE FOR THE CFO ONE MOMENT AND THE LOCAL BUSINESS ANALYST THE NEXT.”

TACKLING PRACTICAL QUESTIONS IN VERIFICATION OF PAYEE'S ROLLOUT



Corporates are preparing for the EU's instant payments regulation, but the path to adopting Verification of Payee is proving complex. Treasury teams are exploring practical ways forward while calling for closer collaboration between banks, regulators and technology providers.

Verification of Payee (VoP) is intended to strengthen security and trust in payments across Europe. By validating beneficiary details before a transfer is executed, the initiative aims to reduce fraud and misdirected payments while boosting confidence in instant payment rails.

With payment service providers (PSPs) expected to meet the October 2025 deadline, corporate treasurers are assessing the impact on their operations. While the principle of VoP is widely supported, reactions vary by market. Norsk Hydro, for instance, is headquartered in Norway and therefore outside of the European Union where the initiative has been developed. But with operations in the Americas, Asia and Oceania in addition to Europe, the company's cross-border payments give its treasury team a distinct perspective on VoP's design and rollout.

Erik Snersrud, Global Head of Payments at Norsk Hydro and a member of the Swift Corporates Working Group, has closely followed the initiative's development. Speaking in a personal capacity, he suggests that the current model "risks becoming something corporates adopt for compliance purposes rather than as a practical tool for fighting fraud".

Pressures and corporate hesitation

For now, Snersrud says many banks and Swift are encouraging corporates to opt out of VoP for bulk, file-based payments, focusing instead on checks for new or amended beneficiaries. With tight deadlines and competing regulatory priorities, institutions are taking a phased approach. Banks and PSPs are investing heavily in their infrastructure, but some functionality is likely to come online gradually.

"The banks are under pressure to meet baseline requirements, so corporates will mainly use VoP through manual checks on online banking portals," notes Snersrud.

Manual processes work for low volumes but are difficult to scale. Corporates are also looking for verification results to feed back into enterprise resource planning (ERP) systems, allowing for automated updates and better audit trails.

"Even when you get a positive match, it just updates a status on the payment," Snersrud explains. "You can't see a master data record that the payee details have been checked. This can be valuable for follow up on the master data as to whether this has been verified or not."

Many treasury teams are therefore adopting a cautious stance, focusing on targeted checks while they monitor progress on regulation and systems. Within the EU, VoP is welcomed as a step forward in fraud prevention, but corporates remain mindful of its operational demands.

Bridging rules and practice

In VoP's early days, there are certain areas where regulation and workflows are not yet aligned. Snersrud points to requirements for single payment checks that could create additional steps for corporates that have opted out of bulk payment verification.

Reliance on name matching is another concern. Names can be altered, misspelt or deliberately manipulated, making this approach less reliable than unique identifiers such as tax or registration numbers.

"We've seen fraud cases where a single letter in a company name was altered, such as swapping an 'i' for a capital 'I'," Snersrud reflects. "That's hard to detect if names are the only point of verification, but will now come as a close match. Reporting in capital letters will make it easier to spot the deviation."

Learning from Brazil's approach

Other jurisdictions provide useful lessons for how VoP could evolve. In Brazil, for example, payments must include both an account number and a taxpayer ID for both individuals and companies, and any mismatch triggers an automatic rejection.

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“It’s simple and effective,” Snersrud points out. “Europe could explore similar approaches, but it’s complicated here because there’s no universal identifier.”

In the EU, identifiers vary. Some countries use VAT numbers, others company registration details, while personal tax IDs are considered too sensitive. Regulators, banks and technology providers are working to improve harmonisation, and initiatives such as the Legal Entity Identifier (LEI) and ISO 20022 messaging are seen as crucial to long-term progress. A personal IBAN ID number in addition to the IBAN can solve the lack of common personal ID across the EU.”

The quest for visibility

Even with stronger verification models, ERP systems will need to adapt to capture and store this data in ways that support automation and compliance.

“I want to see in the master data that an account has been verified, when, and by which source,” Snersrud outlines.

ERP providers are taking a measured approach, often waiting for clear client demand before making significant updates. Given the complexity of global ERP deployments, this caution is understandable, but corporates are eager for solutions that make verification more seamless.

Building a foundation for trust

Banks, too, are playing a vital role in shaping the future of verification. Encouraging corporates to include identifiers such as tax numbers in payment files today could help smooth the transition to more robust verification systems in future.

“Even book transfers could help banks test and refine these processes,” Snersrud suggests. “A collaborative approach would build confidence over time.”

Financial institutions are already investing heavily in fraud prevention tools, enhanced data strategies and infrastructure upgrades as part of the wider shift to instant payments. VoP represents just one element of this broader push to modernise and secure payment systems.

A call for collaboration

Snersrud emphasises that corporates should be actively involved in shaping VoP’s evolution. Industry bodies such as the European Association of Corporate Treasurers have a role to play in ensuring that the practicalities of treasury operations are considered as regulation develops.

“Right now, I think corporates are somewhat stuck,” he says. “Regulators set the rules, banks implement them, and we have to adapt. We need to be more engaged in influencing the process.”

The ongoing migration to ISO 20022 creates opportunities to embed richer data into payments, but real progress will require alignment between regulators, banks and technology providers. “There’s an opportunity to deliver something really valuable,” Snersrud enthuses. “We need more vision and collaboration to make it happen.”

The VoP verdict

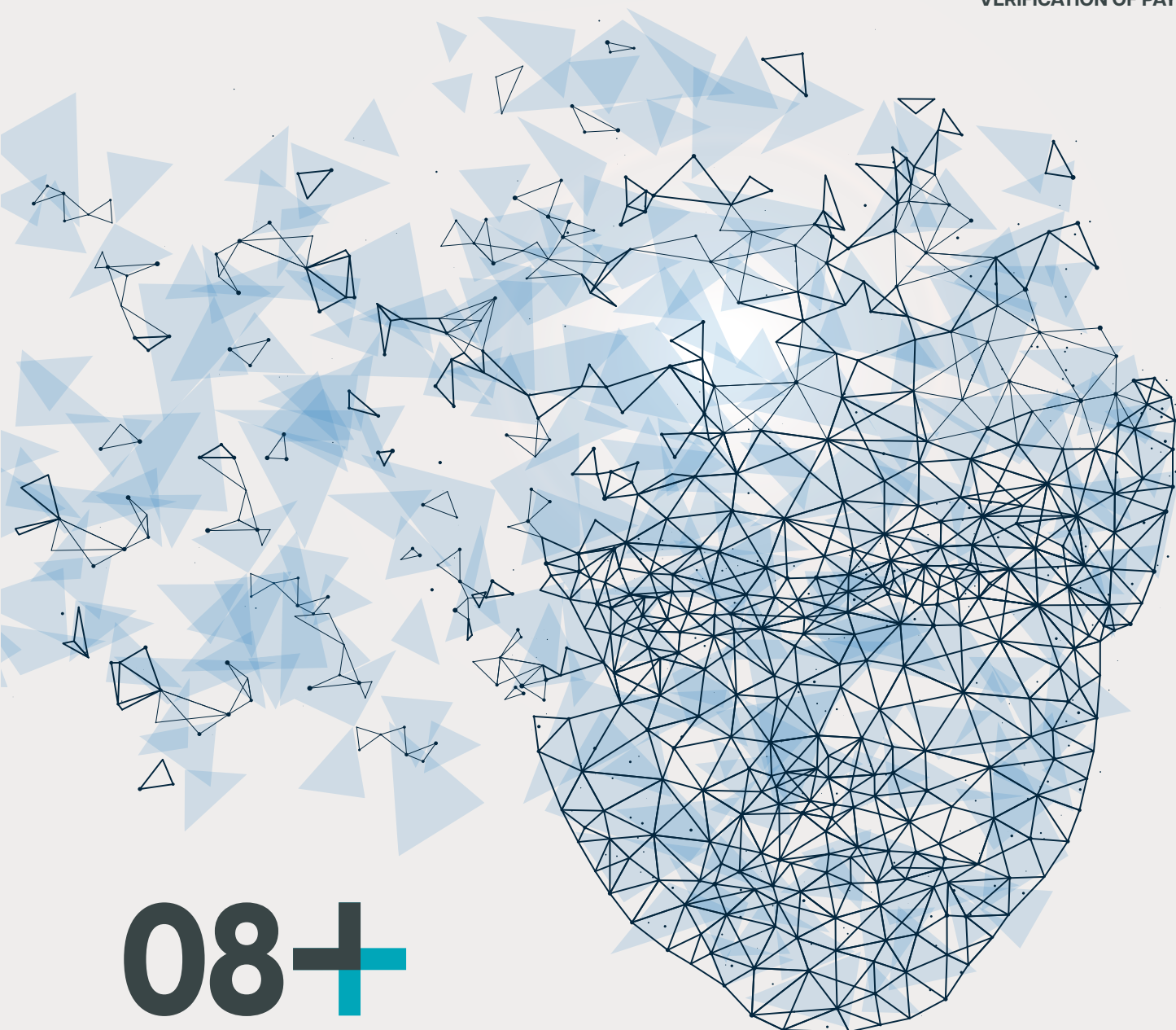
Verification of payee marks a significant step toward building trust and reducing fraud, but corporates continue to face operational challenges. Treasury teams are concentrating on immediate priorities, such as verifying new payees, engaging with banking partners, and supporting industry initiatives aimed at standardising identifiers and data flows.

“As corporates, we can’t just wait for regulators and banks,” Snersrud concludes. “We need to push for better solutions that balance compliance and operational efficiency.”

For their part, banks and technology providers are continuing to invest in modernisation, fraud prevention and richer data capabilities, laying the foundation for a more secure payments environment. Delivering on VoP’s full promise will require all parties to share that responsibility and work together on solutions that meet the needs of businesses and regulators alike.



**“THERE’S AN
OPPORTUNITY TO
DELIVER SOMETHING
REALLY VALUABLE.
WE NEED MORE VISION
AND COLLABORATION TO
MAKE IT HAPPEN.”**



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VERIFICATION OF PAYEE

**A NECESSARY STEP FORWARD
IN EUROPEAN PAYMENTS**

As the EU prepares to mandate Verification of Payee across the SEPA region, its implications are already under scrutiny. For corporates, the road may be bumpy, but with stronger identifiers, clearer implementation rules, and deeper collaboration, the destination is still within reach.

Amid the frustration voiced by some corporates, proponents of Verification of Payee (VoP) are urging a broader perspective. While implementation challenges are real, VoP remains a vital step toward improving payment security, transparency, and confidence in instant rails.

François Masquelier, Chair, the European Association of Corporate Treasurers (EACT), acknowledges the hurdles, but stresses that the bigger picture must not be lost. “VoP has proven its effectiveness domestically in certain countries,” he notes. “We believe that it is ambitious but necessary at the European level to harmonise and impose VoP, first on euro payments and then on other currencies thereafter.”

The introduction of VoP across the EU marks a significant shift in how beneficiary verification is approached. Unlike domestic models, which benefit from common references and tightly integrated banking systems, the European version of VoP must operate across borders, with different legal identifiers and naming conventions.

“No one has ever done this with a cross-border approach to verify the alignment of the legal entity beneficiary and the IBAN,” Masquelier explains. “Given the scale of the task, some difficulties are to be expected. Criticising banks will not advance the debate, but participating will.”

Addressing practical complexities

This tension between ambition and reality is especially visible in use cases involving virtual accounts, which enable corporates to route payments to sub-ledgers tied to a central master account. From a legal standpoint, VoP must verify the owner of the master account, but in practice, corporates often use the underlying operating entity as the payee.

Benedicte Frere, Virtual Account Solutions Product Manager and Payments and Receivables Product Marketing Manager, BNP Paribas, elaborates: “Virtual accounts do not hold a legal value of their own,” she says. “From a strict legal point of view, the VoP check must target the official legal owner of the master account to ensure a full match.”

While the European Payments Council (EPC) rulebook allows for additional data fields in the VoP request to

reference virtual or sub-accounts, this mechanism depends on the ordering party entering both the master account and its legal holder as the beneficiary, with the virtual account referenced as additional information. In reality, that’s often not feasible.

“The ordering party doesn’t often know the master account details, nor do they actually know that they’re paying to a virtual account,” Frere points out. “And in any case, it’s up to the responding bank to decide if they process these additional details in the VoP response at all.”

Banks such as BNP Paribas are exploring workarounds, from whitelisting mechanisms to registering multiple trade names for a single account, to ensure at least a close match. But solving the puzzle doesn’t fall on banks alone. Corporates, too, must play their part.

“Our recommendation for corporates having on-behalf-of structures is to inform their counterparties of this set-up, so they understand who is the legal owner of the account they’re paying to,” Frere adds.

This kind of workaround is not without its challenges, but it reflects an industry trying to scale an obstacle without blocking legitimate payments.

Strengthening the identity layer

Much of the debate around VoP comes down to identifiers: how entities are named, how accounts are labelled, and how regulators, banks, and corporates agree on what ‘matching’ means. The use of legal names alone is often cited as a weak point in current VoP models.

Dr Arif Esa, Global Lead for SAP Treasury and Working Capital Solution, SAP, sees a fundamental gap in how the initiative is being implemented. “The big challenge we see here is the missing standard among different banks,” he states. “Each bank might have its own guidelines for VoP and the way the service will be offered.”

Without harmonisation of the rules and a shared understanding of how additional data fields, virtual account references or aliases should be handled, corporates may be left with an uneven experience, depending on their bank and how the data is dealt with.

“The communication protocol and the connection to a house bank can also influence the way each bank defines its own implementation,” Esa adds. “Without standard and common best practice, the implementation of VoP can be time-consuming and cumbersome.”

This is where global identifiers can make a tangible difference. Clare Rowley, Head of Business Operations, Global Legal Entity Identifier Foundation (GLEIF), believes VoP presents an opportunity to rethink how parties to a transaction are represented. “With the EU leading the way by introducing VoP as a key fraud control for cross-border payments, ERP providers and financial institutions have a unique chance to support this initiative by implementing global identifiers such as the LEI,” she enthuses.

For corporates struggling with name-based checks, an identifier such as the LEI could offer a far more reliable way of verifying counterparties, provided the ecosystem is ready to support it. “Pursuing integration of global identifiers for the account and legal person beneficiary now will help deliver stronger fraud protection for both corporates and consumers, and further the EU’s vision of safer transactions,” Rowley affirms.

The quest for clearer standards

Yet even those who support the direction of VoP are clear-eyed about the gaps in its current design. Masquelier acknowledges that “banks are not and will not be ready” in time for full adoption, and that ERP integration remains a significant hurdle for corporates. But he insists that this is no reason to slow down or scale back the project.

“By imposing this type of standard, the EU is changing the game in Europe and elsewhere,” he observes. “It is a colossal but necessary challenge, particularly for the success of instant payments.”

What is needed is clearer operational guidance from regulators and a stronger push from the industry to align on a common approach. This includes defining how

additional data should be structured, which identifiers are permitted, and how corporates and their systems should interpret responses.

“The EPC leaves it up to the industry to define best practices for these expert use cases,” Frere reflects. “The key challenge is to avoid massive non-execution of valid payments when the underlying legal entity is used as the beneficiary instead of the legal account holder.”

That concern around operational impact underscores the need for closer industry coordination. This is where practical input from the corporate side can be absolutely vital. “The EACT has been actively involved from the early stages, supported by members facing the practical realities on the ground,” Masquelier reveals. “All parties appear committed to making this work, even if success won’t come overnight. In the end, what matters is the result.”

Making trust tangible

VoP was never meant to be a quick fix for fraud. It represents a structural rethink of how payee data is validated, across borders, systems, and a continent still carrying legacy baggage. Getting VoP to work seamlessly across Europe won’t be quick or easy. But the ultimate goal is worth pursuing.

“Verification of Payee will reshape SEPA payments, including for advanced treasury models, so corporates need to adapt their process and work closely with their ERP and TMS providers, but also with their network of customers and suppliers to ensure data accuracy,” Frere urges.

No transformation comes without friction, but with VoP, the building blocks are in place. With continued industry dialogue, support for identifiers, and pragmatic solutions for complex use cases such as virtual accounts, VoP can move from early hurdles to long-term impact, giving treasurers greater confidence in every payment they make or receive.

“VERIFICATION OF PAYEE WILL RESHAPE SEPA PAYMENTS, INCLUDING FOR ADVANCED TREASURY MODELS, SO CORPORATES NEED TO ADAPT THEIR PROCESS AND WORK CLOSELY WITH THEIR ERP AND TMS PROVIDERS.”

VIRTUAL ACCOUNTS AND THE RACE FOR REAL-TIME LIQUIDITY

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Treasurers are intensifying their efforts to achieve instant cash visibility and control. Virtual accounts, APIs, and real-time data offer the potential for faster decision-making and more streamlined operations, as long as integration, regulation, and cultural change are managed carefully.

Corporate treasurers are currently facing a complex mix of market uncertainty, cost pressures, and digital transformation challenges. These forces are prompting treasurers to reassess their approach to managing cash and liquidity.

Dr Arif Esa, Global Lead for SAP Treasury and Working Capital Solution, SAP, explains: “Treasurers are asking how to optimise liquidity in a way that reduces operational costs, leverages technology, and aligns with sustainability obligations.”

For many corporates, rethinking treasury starts with people, not platforms. Shifting behaviours and priorities across the business is often more complex than implementing new technology, yet it’s essential for long-term impact.

“Cash is king and liquidity is queen, but you only succeed if you have a culture that prioritises cash visibility and control, combined with the right technology and processes. It’s not just about treasury systems, it’s about how people across the organisation, including the order-to-cash and source-to-pay departments, approach cash,” Esa adds.

This ambition to centralise and simplify cash structures has long been a focus for treasurers, but rising cost pressures and heightened risk awareness are accelerating the trend. Many are rethinking not just where cash is held but also how it is accessed and managed across regions and subsidiaries.

Stéphanie van der Haert, Treasury Consulting - Director, PwC, reflects: “Treasurers still want the same core things: access and control over their cash, as efficient and as quick as possible. That means a lean banking and bank account structure, as well as leveraging latest technologies, to facilitate the cash centralisation as much as possible, often first into liquidity centres, and then into regional or even global structures.”

Increasingly, those goals are being supported by virtual accounts. Instead of opening multiple physical accounts for every entity or purpose, treasurers can use virtual accounts, essentially multiple sub-ledgers linked to a

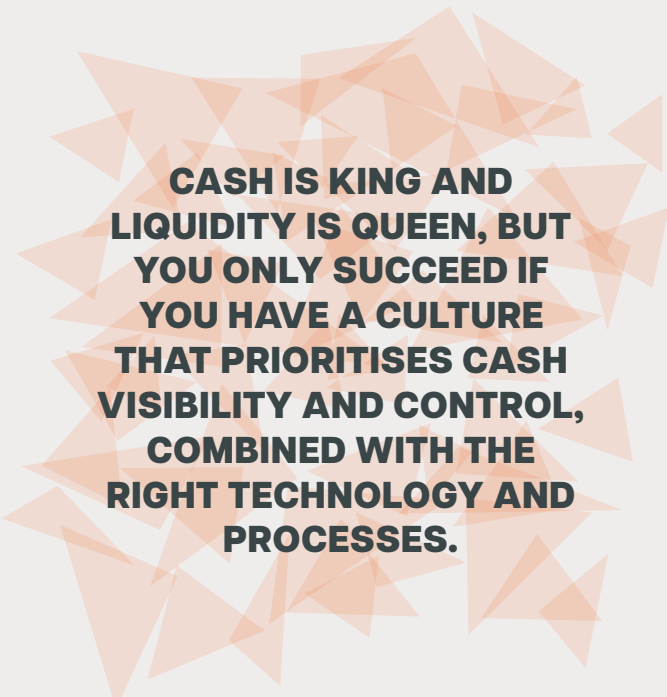
single physical account, to segregate flows, simplify reconciliation, and gain a clearer view of liquidity positions.

Benedicte Frere, Virtual Account Solutions Product Manager and Payments & Receivables Product Marketing Manager, BNP Paribas, notes: “Corporates are always seeking to optimise cash management costs, bank fees, interest expense, borrowing costs, and FX costs. Virtual accounts, combined with better reporting and real-time data, are key enablers of those goals.”

Virtual accounts take centre stage

Virtual accounts have moved beyond niche tasks and are now a mainstream treasury tool. Adoption is rising as corporates look for simpler account structures, faster reconciliation, and sharper liquidity insights.

That momentum is reflected in PwC’s 2025 Global Treasury Survey, which shows that 17% of corporates now use virtual accounts primarily for reconciling incoming payments, up five to six percentage points from two years ago. The use of full IHB functionality, including payments and collections on behalf of (POBO/ COBO) subsidiaries, remains lower at 8%. Still, it is steadily increasing as treasurers test broader applications.



**CASH IS KING AND
LIQUIDITY IS QUEEN, BUT
YOU ONLY SUCCEED IF
YOU HAVE A CULTURE
THAT PRIORITISES CASH
VISIBILITY AND CONTROL,
COMBINED WITH THE
RIGHT TECHNOLOGY AND
PROCESSES.**

One reason for the growing appeal of virtual accounts is their ability to streamline reconciliation. Rather than juggling numerous physical accounts, treasurers can use virtual accounts to segregate flows by business unit, purpose, or geography. This simplifies bank account management while maintaining detailed visibility.

“Being able to reduce the number of physical accounts by replacing them with virtual accounts is still an important driver,” emphasises van der Haert. “It gives treasurers the ability to segregate flows for specific purposes, business units, or geographies without the complexity of opening and closing physical accounts.”

Beyond reconciliation, treasurers are also beginning to utilise virtual accounts for enhanced financial insights. The ability to capture revenue and cost data at a granular level is proving valuable for internal KPI reporting and decision-making.

“Corporates want a more precise view of their revenues and costs, per product line, department, or transaction type,” elaborates Frere. “Virtual accounts are an efficient tool to provide that internal KPI reporting, and we see increasing demand for analytics-driven use cases.”

Banks are responding to corporate demand for virtual accounts with new features. Prominent among these are virtual sweeps that mimic cash pool structures, consolidated reporting at the master account level and multi-currency virtual accounts.

“These developments make it easier to manage international payments for multiple subsidiaries through a single location,” Frere enthuses. “It removes the need to duplicate virtual account references for every subsidiary-currency combination. Enriched reporting is another area we are investing in, where clients can now add their data elements, such as SAP entity IDs or customer IDs, for seamless reconciliation.”

Treasurers also value simplified onboarding. Van der Haert notes: “It’s easier to open and close virtual accounts, and KYC requirements are often lighter compared with physical accounts. That translates into real savings.”

There are also sector-specific differences. Esa observes: “There is robust demand for virtual accounts on the collections side, particularly in e-commerce, rather than for outgoing payments. In-house banks using POBO/COBO models are increasingly exploring how virtual accounts can simplify cash concentration.”

Orchestrating technology and connectivity

Unlocking the full value of virtual accounts takes more than just new bank products. It demands an integrated technology ecosystem. Treasurers require instant data flows between banks, ERP systems, and treasury platforms, often spanning multiple regions and providers. Treasurers are prioritising orchestration as they move closer to real-time liquidity.

SAP’s Esa underlines: “You need an architecture that can pull together all your applications, data, and intelligence tools. That’s when you get a real-time liquidity picture that’s truly actionable, not just semi-automated.”

But integrating those systems is rarely straightforward. API fragmentation remains one major obstacle. “If you talk to two banks, you often get three different answers about APIs,” says Esa. “That’s why corporates are pushing for common standards, whether through Swift or cloud-based multi-bank connectivity platforms.”

Regional differences add another layer of complexity. Some markets are pushing ahead with digital adoption, while others are driven by AI innovation. Some are hindered by regulatory hurdles or legacy infrastructure. “The Nordic countries are very advanced in API and

VIRTUAL ACCOUNTS ARE AN EFFICIENT TOOL TO PROVIDE THAT INTERNAL KPI REPORTING, AND WE SEE INCREASING DEMAND FOR ANALYTICS-DRIVEN USE CASES.

digital adoption, while LATAM are early adopters of real-time connectivity. Europe, despite being digitally strong, can sometimes be slowed by regulatory complexity,” notes Esa.

The rise of fintech and non-bank providers is reshaping how treasurers think about liquidity. New players are creating faster ways to move and reconcile cash, often bypassing traditional channels.

“Big retailers now have banking licences, enabling instant payment reflection in cash forecasts,” says Esa. “Treasurers need to plan for a world where not only banks but also fintechs and payment service providers are part of their liquidity ecosystem.”

Fintechs and non-bank providers are accelerating these shifts, creating new ways to move and reconcile cash outside traditional channels. Payment flows are becoming more fragmented and faster, often outside conventional banking channels. That shift makes connectivity and speed critical, driving treasurers to rethink how they access and utilise liquidity data.

Connected cash management

For many treasurers, the pursuit of real-time liquidity has evolved from an ambition to a practical priority. The goal is no longer just an end-of-day snapshot but continuous, on-demand visibility into every account and transaction.

Van der Haert notes: “Real-time liquidity doesn’t mean much if you don’t have real-time access to data and real-time payment capabilities. It’s really about developing a full real-time treasury function.”

APIs are proving to be the crucial link. While fragmentation among banks remains a significant challenge, the connectivity that treasurers can attain through this technology is transforming banking relationships, providing on-demand reporting and enabling faster decision-making.

Esa explains: “APIs let you request a bank statement on demand instead of waiting for end-of-day files. If banks and ERP vendors work together, treasurers can close the loop, instantly knowing their balance and deciding whether to optimise working capital internally or tap external funding.”

The combination of APIs and virtual accounts is proving especially powerful, as Frere outlines: “Together, they give treasurers another level of real-time, with better accuracy for cash forecasting and automated reconciliation.”



**TREASURERS NEED TO
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Levelling up KPIs with advanced forecasting

Once treasurers have reliable, real-time data, the focus shifts to how that information is used. Treasury teams are moving from static spreadsheets to dynamic, scenario-based models. These tools can reflect changing market conditions and customer behaviours in real time.

“Payment behaviour is changing,” asserts Esa. “Supply chain disruptions, economic shifts all impact when money comes in. You need predictive tools to bridge that uncertainty. The only vehicle we can use right now is scenario simulation and prediction methods using machine learning [ML] and AI.”

Technology is not just improving forecasts but also changing what treasury teams spend their time on. Manual data gathering is giving way to automated processes that deliver instant insight. “Instead of teams spending hours reconciling bank statements, the technology does it instantly,” points out van der Haert. “Treasurers can focus on stress testing different scenarios, such as what happens if a key supplier fails or if currency volatility spikes, and make decisions proactively rather than reactively.”

With more sophisticated forecasting comes a shift in how performance is measured. The conversation is moving from general cash visibility to pinpoint accuracy. Esa points out: “Free cash flow precision, not simply free

cash flow, is now the KPI. It's about how accurately you can forecast and optimise, not just knowing how much you have, but being sure of it to the last decimal."

That accuracy depends on integrating treasury operations tightly with ERP and TMS systems to create a single source of truth. For CFOs, it means greater confidence in funding, investment, and risk management decisions.

Yet even the most effective internal processes function within a wider regulatory and risk landscape. Policy changes, compliance requirements, and fraud prevention measures impact how swiftly and reliably cash can be transferred.

Regulation's double-edged sword

Regulation is playing a dual role in treasury transformation: creating opportunities for stronger risk controls but also introducing new compliance demands. For treasurers seeking real-time liquidity, these issues matter because faster money movement and instant data rely on equally fast fraud prevention and regulatory checks.

Improved forecasting and greater precision already help treasurers detect fraud and manage market risk in near real time, for example. Esa notes: "If you can track all transactions at the virtual account level, you can avoid fraud on the fly and be a stronger partner for risk managers. That supports better, faster hedging decisions, especially when FX markets are volatile or when market windows are short."

Regulation is amplifying these efforts. Frere highlights EU ALM 2024/1640 and Payment Services Directive 3 (PSD3) as positive steps because they "make virtual accounts more transparent and enhance their legal framework". PSD3, in particular, provides a formal definition of virtual accounts aligned with SEPA and

ISO standards, while ALM 2024/1640 requires virtual accounts to be listed in national account registers. These steps support real-time liquidity by strengthening confidence in the accounts and ownership structures behind the flows.

However, not every regulatory change is frictionless. Verification of Payee (VoP) checks, designed to combat fraud, present challenges for POBO/COBO structures. "VoP checks look at the legal owner of the physical account, not necessarily the subsidiary entity using a virtual account," reflects Frere. "Without an industry standard for handling this, corporates could face a wave of mismatched payments when VoP goes live." That risk is magnified in a real-time world, where a failed payment or a delay in validation can ripple quickly through liquidity positions.

Many of these challenges stem from poor master and transactional data. Inaccurate information leads to flawed decisions, so clean and reliable data are essential. "Corporates need accurate, unique identifiers for their beneficiaries," says Esa. "That means investing in better data governance so you're not resolving mismatches after the fact." Clean data and strong governance are now essential not only for regulatory compliance but also for real-time decision-making.

KYC processes are also evolving. For on-behalf-of structures, the lighter KYC for virtual accounts can be a real incentive compared with traditional physical accounts, but getting the set-up right is vital.

"Corporates need to check how their ERP or treasury systems handle a large volume of virtual accounts, their related flows, and virtual sweeps effectively," urges van der Haert. That readiness is essential when liquidity structures are expected to run continuously and with minimal manual intervention.

FREE CASH FLOW PRECISION, NOT SIMPLY FREE CASH FLOW, IS NOW THE KPI. IT'S ABOUT HOW ACCURATELY YOU CAN FORECAST AND OPTIMISE, NOT JUST KNOWING HOW MUCH YOU HAVE, BUT BEING SURE OF IT TO THE LAST DECIMAL.

Treasury culture in the real-time era

Of course, technology alone can't deliver the benefits without corresponding changes to people and processes. Real-time liquidity requires changes in mindset and workflow as much as in systems. Treasury teams need to break down silos, collaborate more closely with other functions, and embed cash awareness across the organisation.

That shift changes the nature of treasury roles. Many teams that once spent days compiling and reconciling data are moving towards higher-value work, such as stress testing and strategic decision-making. At the same time, real-time capabilities demand new skills, including data interpretation, scenario modelling, and comfort with predictive technologies such as AI and ML.

Van der Haert elaborates: "Real-time liquidity impacts people and processes, not just systems. Treasury teams must be ready to interpret information in real time and act on it, whether that's funding decisions, investments, or FX hedging."

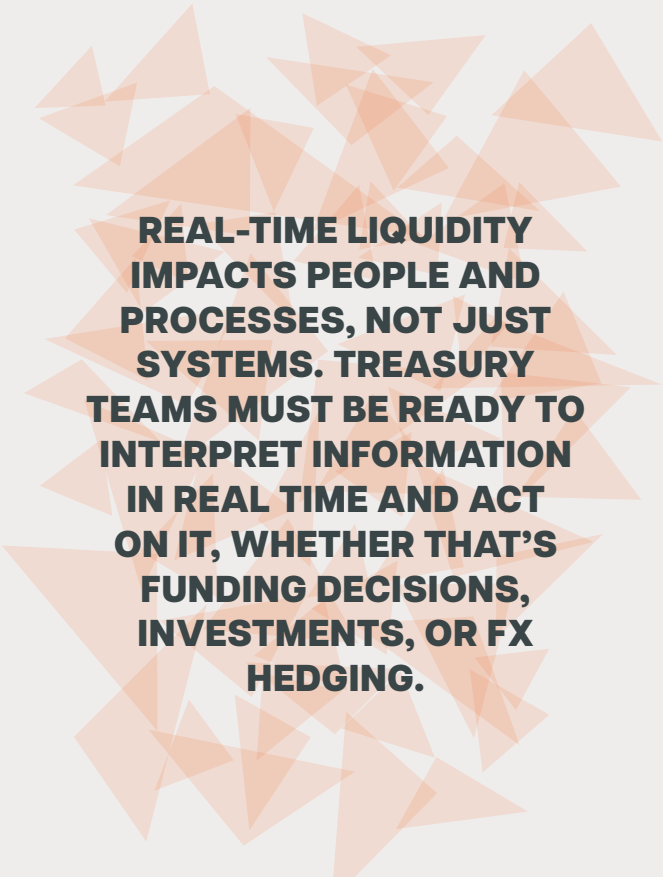
Once processes and teams are aligned, the benefits become clear. Faster, data-driven decisions translate into cost savings and operational efficiencies. With real-time liquidity, treasurers can make funding and investment decisions more quickly and with greater confidence.

"Real-time liquidity translates into hard savings," affirms van der Haert. "There is less need for buffers, better investment decisions, lower funding costs, and also process efficiencies, because automation reduces manual follow-up and forecasting complexity."

Banks are also responding with solutions designed to accelerate the transition to real-time liquidity. New capabilities such as virtual sweeps and consolidated reporting automate cash concentration across subsidiaries and currencies. These features enable treasurers to view and deploy cash globally in near real-time, which is essential for those implementing POBO/COBO structures, seeking instant funding, or making real-time investment decisions.

Towards a 'symphony of systems'

The adoption of real-time payments, APIs, and virtual account structures is accelerating as treasurers move closer to achieving instant visibility and control over their cash. PwC's survey shows that 20% of respondents have already implemented real-time payments, and another 34% plan to do so soon. API use cases are expanding, with



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65% of the corporates surveyed intending to extend or enhance them. Virtual account usage is also increasing, supported by a technology stack that is evolving at a rapid pace.

This shift is also changing how treasurers view virtual accounts. Van der Haert notes that while they play a vital role in streamlining cash flows, they are only one part of a broader transformation. "Virtual accounts are an enabler, but they're just one piece of a real-time treasury function. As payments, data and liquidity management all become real-time, the benefits multiply."

Frere sees the next frontier in layering intelligence onto this infrastructure. "When you add AI on top of virtual accounts and APIs, you get higher accuracy in identifying cash shortages or surpluses and even enabling automated investments," she affirms. "Tokenisation of cash balances through blockchain is another frontier, moving liquidity as a programmable asset based on smart contract conditions."

This evolution depends on systems working in harmony, with data flowing freely between applications. Esa concludes: "If you can integrate your applications, data, and AI into a coherent whole, that's when you get true real-time liquidity. It's a vision of a symphony of systems, where decisions are instant and insight-driven."

RACING THE CLOCK AND WINNING!

**HOW ACCELL GROUP
BUILT AN IN-HOUSE BANK
IN JUST THREE MONTHS**

CS10+



Faced with a product recall and €1bn in excess inventory in quick succession, Accell Group's treasury team found themselves facing a steep uphill climb. Their response: a full pivot from traditional cash pooling to an integrated in-house bank, all of which was designed, constructed, and implemented in record time.

Accell Group, known for iconic cycling brands such as Batavus, Lapierre, Raleigh, and Haibike, has been through a turbulent few years. The pandemic sparked surging demand, followed by sharp supply chain disruptions and shifting customer behaviour.

Tjitze Auke Rijpkema, Head of Treasury Operations, reflects: "The past couple of years felt like a mountain stage in an elite cycling race such as the prestigious Tour de France. It has been so intense, full of uphill battles and requiring serious endurance. But as a bike company, we know what it takes to get through those tough climbs."

The pressure mounted quickly. When Covid-19 hit in 2020, Accell scrambled to secure additional funding. Then came the boom.

"At a certain point in lockdown, we could have sold bikes with square wheels," Rijpkema recalls. "Simply put, sales were going through the roof."

But the high didn't last. Global logistics issues delayed shipments, while dealers began slashing orders in a move that took the cycling industry by surprise, just as inventory levels were ballooning. By 2023, Accell was sitting on nearly €1.1bn in stock against revenue of around €1.4bn. This elevated level of stock resulted in significant leverage that, combined with a decrease in sales, led to several downgrades to the group's credit rating.

Then, just a few months after the company was downgraded to CCC, another blow. A recall of cargo bikes hit the cycling manufacturing industry.

Behind the scenes, the treasury team was trying to keep pace with increasingly strained banking relationships. As the company's credit ratings dropped, its crucial multi-entity notional cash pool came under unsustainable pressure.

When the well dries up

Accell's treasury model had long revolved around a sophisticated notional cash pool. "At the time, without the cash pool, we could not operate," underlines Rijpkema.

It helped net more than €1bn in internal balances, facilitated intercompany payments, and streamlined FX exposures across 39 legal entities.

But the rating downgrades, prompted by the excess inventory and disrupted revenues, began to ripple through its banking relationships.

"Naturally, our cash-pooling bank was getting cold feet, so the cash pool was no longer an option for us," Rijpkema acknowledges.

The bank gave a hard deadline. Accell had just three months to replace the cash pool with a different solution. After a thorough investigation of possible options, the treasury opted to implement an in-house bank (IHB) as the best solution for its new situation.

The blueprint for something better

With the countdown already ticking, Accell's treasury team needed a solution that could replace the functionality of the notional cash pool without disrupting existing operations. "The cash pool used to be the heart of our whole treasury operation," emphasises Rijpkema. Its removal threatened to break multiple links in the group's liquidity chain.

The new set-up had to preserve core capabilities, restore confidence with both banks and internal stakeholders, and do so at a rapid pace. Accell landed on a semi-automated IHB that would manage payments-on-behalf-of (POBO), intercompany non-cash settlements, automated sweeps and ERP-integrated reporting.

The IHB was designed to support these four core functions in a way that delivers a high level of standardisation across entities and far greater automation in the payment processes, all while reducing reliance on external banking infrastructure. The goal wasn't simply to replace the crucial cash pool, but to go above and beyond it in every conceivable way.

However, the project had to meet the tight deadline. That meant keeping existing interfaces and workflows wherever possible. "We needed to keep the current

processes and infrastructure as intact as possible due to the strict three-month deadline,” explains Rijpkema.

Three months to reinvent the wheel

Rather than redesign payment flows from the ground up, the team took a pragmatic approach. Local entities continued preparing payment files as usual. Integration software intercepted those files, routed them through the new IHB engine, and then classified each transaction accordingly.

“At the IHB, the files are parsed and separated into POBO and intercompany payments, and the payment files for external parties are updated so that the actual payments are debited from the relevant group accounts,” outlines Rijpkema.

Once transformed, the files are sent to the payment hub for approval and then transmitted to the banks. At the same time, the system recorded an IHB entry, essentially an intercompany loan, between treasury and the operating company.

Previously, intercompany settlements relied on actual cash movements between accounts. Now, these flows are processed internally on a non-cash basis. “After the parsing and separation... the intercompany payments are immediately processed in the IHB, on a non-cash basis, of course,” clarifies Rijpkema. This shift reduces transaction costs and simplifies liquidity planning without disrupting the underlying commercial flows.

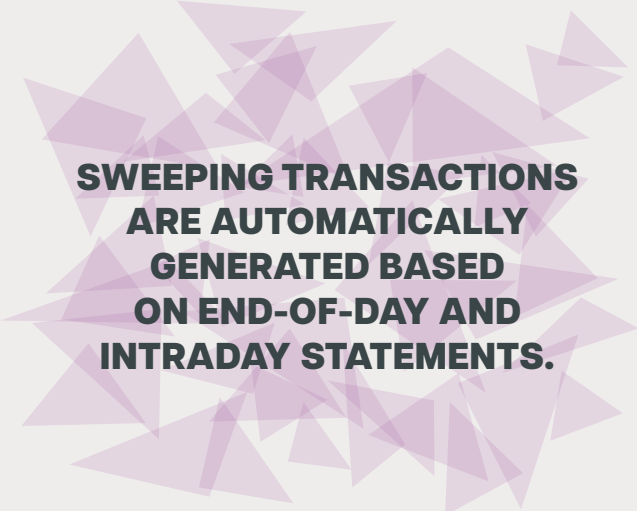
This architecture has enabled Accell’s treasury to preserve local autonomy, avoid retraining staff across dozens of business units, and meet its urgent deadline without cutting corners.

Automating the liquidity flow

One significant challenge for this project was replicating the liquidity centralisation benefits of the notional pool. To tackle this issue, Accell leaned heavily on automation and data.

“Sweeping transactions are automatically generated based on end-of-day and intraday statements, along with data from our payment hub about pending supplier payments for that day,” Rijpkema explains.

The system checks current balances and expected outflows before triggering a sweep. Thresholds established by the treasury ensure that only meaningful



SWEEPING TRANSACTIONS ARE AUTOMATICALLY GENERATED BASED ON END-OF-DAY AND INTRADAY STATEMENTS.

transfers are executed, helping to avoid unnecessary movements and improve cash efficiency.

“The system uses predefined parameters such as minimum balances and transaction amounts to decide whether to sweep funds to the group or provide funding to local accounts,” Rijpkema adds. Each sweep also generates a corresponding booking in the IHB, maintaining accurate intercompany records.

This framework has improved Accell’s cash visibility and reduced manual intervention. Treasury can now see and manage liquidity across the group with precision, even in volatile conditions.

No blind spots, no fire drills

Building an effective IHB isn’t just about processing payments or centralising cash. Visibility, compliance, and data integrity are equally important. Accell’s TMS and integration layers play a crucial role here as well.

“At the end of each day, our TMS generates statements automatically, which are then picked up by the integration software and sent to the various ERPs across the group,” affirms Rijpkema.

A robust control framework backs these processes. Daily checks confirm that transactions have posted correctly. Alerts are sent if an issue crops up, such as a file that can’t be processed or a delay in end-of-day reconciliation. This combination of proactive controls and automated ERP reporting means treasury no longer relies on end-of-month fire drills.

A leaner, stronger treasury

What began as a crisis response evolved into a strategic breakthrough. By focusing on speed, clarity, and fit-for-

purpose functionality, Rijpkema and his team have created a system that is far more agile than the previous set-up.

“We have achieved amazing results,” he enthuses. “These include a high level of automation and standardisation in our payment processes, a significant reduction of bank accounts, with around 150 closed, which also led to a significant reduction in transaction fees. As a treasury, we are now in full control of all our payment processes, which is a huge positive.”

As a result of all the hard work and success over the past seven years, the treasury team at Accell has improved its position within the company. While the treasury function has always been viewed as adding value to the company, this change has further strengthened the department as a proactive driver of operational efficiency and financial insight. With fewer accounts, increased automation, and tighter data flows, treasury is better positioned to support the group’s evolving needs.

Cultural shift and collaboration

The success that Accell’s treasury unlocked did not come solely from systems. The lean approach to project management was also critical.

“We deliberately kept our team small to avoid unnecessary delays due to the strict deadline,” reveals Rijpkema. “That helped ensure fast and direct communication, which enabled us to stay agile and make decisions quickly.”

The team also partnered with an external consultant who played a vital role in shaping the project. “They developed custom functionality tailored to how we wanted the IHB to operate,” Rijpkema adds. “And just as importantly, they were fully aligned with our goals and shared our urgency to meet the deadline. It was a wonderful collaboration.”

The experience has strengthened both internal and external relationships. Teams across finance, IT, and operations are now more integrated, and the treasury team has gained confidence in driving change under pressure.

From trophies to takeaways

The project to implement a fully integrated IHB in only three months has rightfully earned formal recognition, winning both the Dutch Association of Corporate Treasurers (DACT) Treasury Award 2024 and the European Association of Corporate Treasurers (EACT) Treasury Award 2025.

“It was a proud moment for all of us,” reflects Rijpkema. “It can be easy to get caught up in day-to-day deliverables when working in treasury, so moments like this always give you a chance to pause and reflect on the broader impacts of your work.”

But that work isn’t finished yet. With the foundations now in place, Accell is exploring further automation, more robust forecasting, and new reporting capabilities. The goal is to build on what was achieved under pressure and extend it into a long-term platform for even smarter, more strategic treasury management.

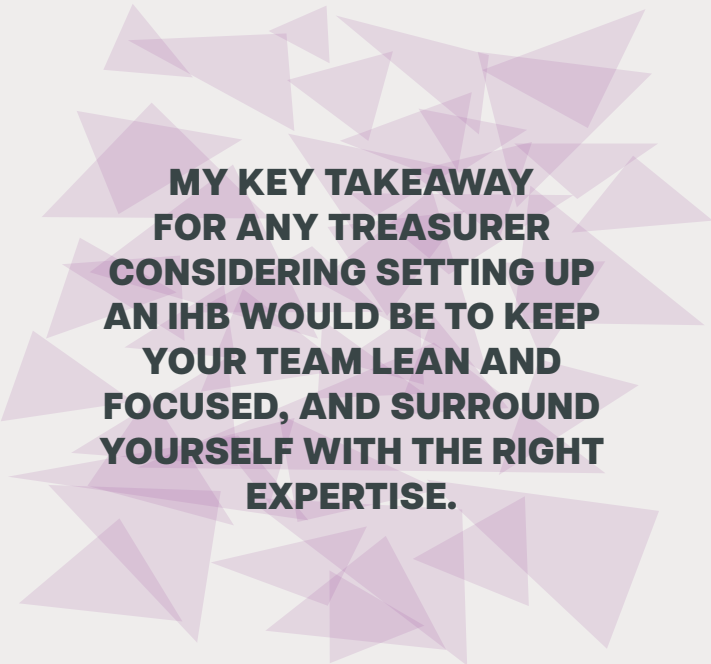
For treasury teams considering implementing their own IHB, Rijpkema offers both encouragement and caution.

“My key takeaway for any treasurer considering setting up an IHB would be to keep your team lean and focused, and surround yourself with the right expertise,” he advises.

This involves selecting internal champions, securing executive sponsorship, and collaborating with vendors and consultants who genuinely understand the business. It also means being realistic. Not every process can be perfect on the first day.

“Stay focused, collaborate closely, and make sure your IHB works for you and not the other way around,” Rijpkema concludes.

From a cash pool to an IHB in just 12 weeks, Accell’s journey offers a model of what treasury can accomplish when clarity, commitment, and creativity come together under pressure.



**MY KEY TAKEAWAY
FOR ANY TREASURER
CONSIDERING SETTING UP
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EXPERTISE.**

AI'S TREASURY MOMENT

FROM HYPE TO HANDS ON

AI is no longer a distant promise. Step by step, treasury teams are using it to rethink how they work by combining data, technology, and human judgment. From virtual assistants to predictive models, real-world use cases are beginning to deliver results.

11+

It's 9 a.m. on a Monday, and a junior treasury analyst needs to check the group's US dollar exposure ahead of a volatile trading day. Instead of chasing down spreadsheets or emailing regional teams, they open the firm's AI-powered chatbot and type: "What's our net USD exposure for this week?" The response is instant, pulled from live systems, summarised clearly, and flagged with key variances. Five minutes later, they're ready for the CFO's morning call.

Scenes such as this are becoming more common and more powerful. As AI begins to integrate into treasury workflows, the focus is shifting from hype to practical application. But for many treasurers, the starting point with this technology remains unclear.

Rather than pushing a sweeping transformation narrative, most successful adoption of AI relies on patience, pragmatism, and preparation. The firms seeing progress today are those treating AI as an enabler of specific goals, not an end in itself.

Dr Arif Esa, Global Lead & Chief Solution Expert, SAP Treasury and Working Capital Solution, SAP, emphasises: "There's a lot of noise and expectation, but not always the foundation to support it. Treasury functions don't need moonshots. They need tools that help them do their jobs better."

Getting the data right

If there's one consistent message fed back from those further along the AI adoption path, it's that AI success starts with good data.

Treasury teams typically hold large volumes of data, but that doesn't mean they are ready to use it. Siloed systems, inconsistent formats, and patchy access rights are all common hurdles. In many cases, firms are still grappling with basics such as building a unified data layer, implementing common standards, and establishing secure pathways for information to flow.

As such, expectations need to be grounded in current capabilities. "If your treasury doesn't already have clean, well-structured data, introducing AI will likely compound the chaos," Esa notes. "That's why we sometimes say you need to use AI to prepare for AI."

In practice, that means starting with tools that help clean or organise the data itself, laying the groundwork for more advanced use cases later on. This is where many treasurers find themselves today: not standing still, but cleaning up master data, improving system integrations, and investing in governance frameworks.

Jan Dirk van Beusekom, Head of Strategic Marketing Cash Management & Payments, BNP Paribas, reflects: "Everyone talks about use cases and the art of the possible. However, the reality is that many treasury functions are still focused on fixing the pipes. And that's fine. Without that step, you can't build anything useful on top."

Once the basics are in place, some firms are focusing on the next layer by developing a semantic structure. This shared language for defining and accessing key data points across the enterprise enables treasury teams to transition from fragmented reporting to meaningful comparisons.

Simon Tytgat, Manager within PwC Belgium's Treasury consulting practice, explains: "A semantic layer helps you compare apples with apples. Without it, you're spending time explaining discrepancies instead of acting on insights."

Ownership is another crucial factor that is often complex and easily underestimated. While treasury may operate at group level, much of the relevant data sits in country-specific or business unit systems. Gaining access to this information, both legally and operationally, can delay AI initiatives for months.

From buzzwords to business value

Much of the current noise around AI in financial services focuses on generative AI (GenAI), particularly large language models (LLMs). However, this is just one subset of the AI landscape.

"IF YOUR TREASURY DOESN'T ALREADY HAVE CLEAN, WELL-STRUCTURED DATA, INTRODUCING AI WILL LIKELY COMPOUND THE CHAOS".

Esa points out: “When people say ‘AI’, they might mean deep learning, machine learning, or generative AI. These are different tools with different strengths.”

In treasury, traditional ML models trained on historical data to make predictions are already delivering tangible value in areas such as cash forecasting, fraud detection, and working capital optimisation. Esa describes these as the “low-hanging fruit” of AI adoption.

“We’ve been using predictive algorithms in treasury for years,” he adds. “What’s changing is the ability to embed them more seamlessly into workflows. You don’t need to call it AI for it to deliver value.”

Indeed, many of the most effective use cases today rely on relatively simple models, wrapped in user-friendly interfaces and supported by robust data pipelines. “The real innovation is orchestration,” Esa emphasises: “How you co-ordinate application, data, and decision-makers is where the impact lies.”

That orchestration isn’t just technical. It’s changing how treasury teams structure and execute their day-to-day work.

Building intelligent workflows

Rather than aiming for AI-driven automation across the board, the focus now is on building smarter, more connected processes.

This includes creating virtual assistants to support everyday tasks, such as generating reports and explaining unusual variances in a cash position. It also provides for the use of agent-based models, where AI tools simulate different stakeholder behaviours to help treasurers make more informed decisions.

“You can think of it as agent-to-agent collaboration,” reveals Esa. “You give each AI agent a role – maybe one is the cash manager, one is the risk officer – and they propose strategies based on their priorities. That gives the human user better inputs to work with.”

Crucially, these approaches don’t replace treasury teams but rather augment them. They also don’t require a total overhaul.

Tytgat suggests: “Treasurers can start small and don’t need to rebuild their architecture. Rather, they need to identify a problem, isolate the relevant data, and test a targeted solution. This avoids a complete system overhaul and offers a practical route for AI adoption.”

This modular approach of building out use cases one layer at a time is fast becoming the norm. It enables treasury functions to scale at their own pace, while still delivering incremental improvements. And while every firm’s journey looks different, a few use cases are beginning to stand out.

Use cases gaining traction

A prime example of AI in treasury is intercompany lending. AI tools can now analyse historical payment behaviours, cash positions, and FX exposures to help automate the allocation of internal loans. In more advanced set-ups, these tools act as part of a wider ‘deal agent’ function that reviews forecasts, identifies surpluses or shortfalls, and initiates transactions for approval before triggering market trades or MMF allocations.

Van Beusekom enthuses: “Intercompany lending is one of the areas where efficiency gains are very real. We’ve seen clients reduce reconciliation cycles significantly.”

The concept of intelligent orchestration, where multiple agents support specific parts of the cash conversion cycle (CCC), is gaining ground rapidly. Esa outlines a scenario in which receivables, payables, inventory, cash, and deal agents interact dynamically.

“If my DSO goes down, I get cash five days earlier, I invest sooner. On the payables side, I can rate my vendors and offer discounts to optimise DPO. Meanwhile, my inventory strategy must adapt to tariffs and global disruptions. If those agents are communicating properly, you have a much tighter and more predictive cash conversion cycle.”

Esa’s example reflects a broader trend. Among treasury functions, working capital stands out as a logical proving ground for AI tools. AI-powered collection agents can now flag anomalies in client payment patterns, recommend actions such as issuing dispute notices or credit memos, and help reduce DSO without intensive manual chasing.

On the payables side, AI tools are being utilised to classify vendors and identify dynamic discounting opportunities, thereby enhancing liquidity outcomes. Treasurers are also exploring how AI could enhance inventory financing decisions, particularly as the shift from ‘just-in-time’ to ‘just-in-case’ supply chains continues.

Cash flow forecasting is another area gaining traction, particularly as treasurers look to connect working capital decisions with broader liquidity planning. While forecasting tools have been around for years, many still rely on black-box models that offer little insight into

what's driving the numbers. The introduction of GenAI is transforming both usability and transparency.

Tytgat reveals: "Cash forecasts used to give treasurers just a number. Now, they allow for dynamic interaction. A treasurer could ask why they're short US\$2m, for example, and the forecast can tell you it's due to a large scheduled purchase or an uptick in manufacturing costs. It can even suggest how to close the gap."

This kind of interaction is already live in some treasury set-ups. Agents can propose internal transfers, send transactions for approval, and reconcile payments post-settlement, all while keeping the treasurer informed.

AI-driven fraud detection is evolving beyond bank-led surveillance to benefit corporate treasurers directly. Pattern recognition, sanctions screening, and anomaly detection are being embedded into payment platforms and dashboards, enabling earlier interventions. As van Beusekom puts it: "We proactively take action when we see a pattern that doesn't fit. It's not just a bank tool any more."

Other innovations target day-to-day pain points. BNP Paribas's intelligent payment assistant, for example, helps corporates navigate complex cross-border payment rules by drawing on public and internal data sources. If a treasurer wants to pay a supplier in Vietnamese dong, the assistant can provide the correct Swift or XML message format, currency restrictions, and other regulatory requirements in seconds. The bank's universal payment inquiry tool also supports faster reconciliation by enabling structured queries across ISO 20022 datasets.

Taken together, these use cases point to a more modular, cumulative approach to AI adoption that prioritises precision and usability over dramatic transformation. Each tool may address a specific pain point, but the broader ambition is clear: a treasury function that's better informed, more responsive, and ready to act.

Securing buy-in, managing risk

Even where the technology is ready, adoption still hinges on trust, both within treasury and across the wider organisation. That trust often begins with collaboration, as implementing AI in treasury is rarely a solo effort. It depends on close alignment with IT, Compliance, Finance, and Legal, each of which brings different priorities and constraints.

Tytgat reveals: "It's not just a treasury question, it's a business-wide conversation. You need alignment with IT

on infrastructure, with Compliance on controls, and with leadership on priorities."

Esa notes that the most successful AI projects he has seen are driven by multidisciplinary teams. "Bring in Operations, Legal, HR, even Procurement. The more perspectives you have, the more robust your solution becomes."

This alignment becomes even more critical when it comes to securing budget, building trust in outputs, and ensuring auditability.

Van Beusekom underlines: "You can have the best AI tool in the world, but if your CFO doesn't trust the output, you won't get far. That's why governance, auditability, and explainability matter so much."

Esa agrees that auditability is becoming a central design principle. "CFOs are asking, 'If I get this result today, will I get the same one tomorrow with the same inputs?' That consistency matters."

Yet even with governance in place, defining success can be difficult. Traditional treasury KPIs can fail to capture the full value of AI initiatives, and in some cases they may even obscure it.

Tytgat cautions against measuring performance by the number of models deployed or the volume of data processed. "If there's no measurable outcome, it's just noise," he warns.

Instead, the emphasis is shifting to real-world results, such as reduced DSO, improved forecasting accuracy, quicker

"EVEN WHERE THE TECHNOLOGY IS READY, ADOPTION STILL HINGES ON TRUST, BOTH WITHIN TREASURY AND ACROSS THE WIDER ORGANISATION".

fraud detection, or faster reactions to volatility. These are the metrics that resonate with CFOs and help justify further investment.

Treasury, unlike more experimental parts of the business, doesn't have the luxury of trial and error. The stakes are high and the margin for error is slim. Corporate finance teams must understand not only what a model says but why it says it. This is prompting a renewed focus on transparency and oversight. Some firms are setting up AI steering committees. Others are adapting model risk frameworks from the banking world to track algorithm performance over time.

"We've seen companies adapting risk models from financial institutions," Tytgat shares. "It's about bringing rigour to something that can otherwise feel like a black box."

'Start with what hurts'

New technologies often reach the largest corporates first, thanks to their deeper budgets and specialist teams. But AI is proving to be a different story. As off-the-shelf tools become more powerful and intuitive, smaller treasury teams are finding ways to adopt AI at their own pace, targeting specific pain points rather than pursuing full-scale transformation. Cloud-based solutions and embedded tools are aiding this accessibility.

Esa underlines: "It's not about who has the most data. It's about who can use it most effectively. A mid-market corporate with clean, well-structured data can sometimes move faster than a large multinational with legacy systems."

Many banks are now supporting clients through curated AI offerings, helping treasury teams identify relevant use cases, set up data infrastructure, and monitor results.

Van Beusekom explains: "It's becoming more of a co-creation model. Banks aren't just selling a product. They're helping clients get ready."

That readiness looks different for everyone. For some, it means running pilot projects in specific areas, such as intercompany lending or payment reconciliation. For others, it means focusing on the fundamentals: better visibility, faster reporting, tighter controls.

What matters most is that the business case is clear. "Start with what hurts," advises Tytgat. "Where are you spending too much time? Where are the errors? Where's the delay? That's where AI can help."

Enabling people rather than replacing

For all the focus on systems and models, AI adoption is also a people challenge. Treasury teams must navigate not only new tools but also sometimes internal resistance from staff who are anxious about job security or overwhelmed by unfamiliar technology. The key is to build confidence, not just capability.

Van Beusekom advises: "You need champions across the business, not just in treasury. Finance, IT, and Compliance all have a stake. If they're not aligned, you'll hit roadblocks."

This is where generational shifts can play a role. As younger finance professionals join the workforce, expectations are changing.

Tytgat notes: "The next generation is used to instant answers and seamless interfaces. They'll ask why their tools at work aren't as intuitive as the ones they use at home."

At the same time, the growing visibility of AI in treasury is opening new paths for talent development. Tech-savvy staff are finding more opportunities to shape strategy, while seasoned treasury professionals are being upskilled to work alongside intelligent systems.

Building the right culture takes time, but it is central to long-term success. AI in treasury isn't about replacing people; it's about enabling them to deliver more value in a more complex environment.

A long game, worth playing

Looking ahead, the most mature treasury teams won't necessarily be those with the flashiest tools, but those with the clearest sense of purpose.

Van Beusekom emphasises: "AI isn't something you implement once and forget about. It's a mindset shift. You're building capabilities that will evolve."

That evolution will take different forms: from real-time scenario planning to autonomous liquidity management. But the underlying principle remains the same. AI should enhance treasury's ability to anticipate, act, and advise. It's also an opportunity to reshape how treasury is perceived.

Esa concludes: "When you combine automation with insight, you create space for strategic thinking. That's how treasury moves from score keeper to strategic partner."



CS12+

REWIRING TREASURY AT ZOETIS

Twelve years after spinning out from Pfizer, Zoetis has built a lean, centralised treasury that is digitally enabled and strategically engaged. Assistant Treasurer Michel Verholen reflects on the tools and tactics behind the transformation and how visibility, automation, and AI are setting the stage for what is ahead.

Zoetis is one of the world's leading animal health companies, operating in more than 100 markets and with a direct presence in around half. It supplies vaccines, diagnostics, and pharmaceutical products for livestock and pets, helping veterinarians and farmers care for animals.

Since becoming an independent company in 2013, Zoetis has achieved consistent growth with revenues now exceeding US\$9bn. For Verholen, this growth has brought both complexity and opportunity.

"We provide the core services to the organisation, so we're thinking about liquidity and funding optimisation across our global entities, managing FX risk, and overseeing banking relationships," he says. "We also guide the business on capital allocation, planning, and working capital."

The treasury model is deliberately centralised. While the function spans multiple teams and locations, it operates under one unified structure and methodology. "We typically do not have anybody touching treasury outside of our own function," Verholen reveals. That tight integration creates much-needed visibility and a shared focus across all treasury activities.

Early wins from digitisation

Back in 2018, Zoetis featured in the Journeys to Treasury report regarding its co-creation efforts with BNP Paribas to digitise account opening and build a banking dashboard. These projects were early indicators that the team was heading towards a more automated, data-led treasury.

The shift from paper-based forms to digital formats was just the beginning. Over time, these foundations enabled broader digitisation, as Zoetis used technology to reshape workflows, strengthen controls, and improve internal decision-making.

That same approach also helped pave the way for broader adoption across the company's bank

relationships. Six years on, both initial initiatives continue to deliver value. Perhaps even more crucially, they helped to pave the way for broader adoption across the company's bank relationships.

"Digitisation of the account opening process has seen much wider adoption, not only at BNP Paribas but across many other banks," Verholen explains. "I'm happy to be part of that co-creation, but I'm even more happy that other banks have adopted similar digital solutions."

That digitised account opening process has since become the foundation for wider onboarding and compliance efficiencies. In many cases, the same infrastructure is now used to support KYC requirements, both at the point of onboarding and throughout the account life cycle.

Meanwhile, the benefits of the bank connectivity dashboard remain consistent. It provides a clear, group-wide view of account structures and payment activity, helping the team identify where to rationalise. Whether it's closing dormant accounts or analysing payment types, the dashboard remains an essential tool for operational focus.

From tools to insight and action

While some digital solutions have matured quietly in the background, others have taken centre stage. One that stands out is the adoption of end-to-end payment tracking via Swift GPI, a practical solution that has proven to be transformative.

"When payments are disputed or delayed, you can now see exactly where they are stuck," Verholen underlines. "It's particularly useful when beneficiaries claim there's been a deduction. More often than not, we can demonstrate that the deduction happened on their correspondent side, not ours."

As well as transparency around payment location and timing, it also reveals where fees are deducted along the payment chain. This equips treasury with the data it needs to defend its position and improve service quality.

Alongside payment tracking, other technologies have quietly reshaped the team's day-to-day operations. Electronic signatures, once resisted in many jurisdictions, are now accepted widely, even in countries where paper-based processes were the norm. "That's brought immediate efficiency gains," Verholen confirms.

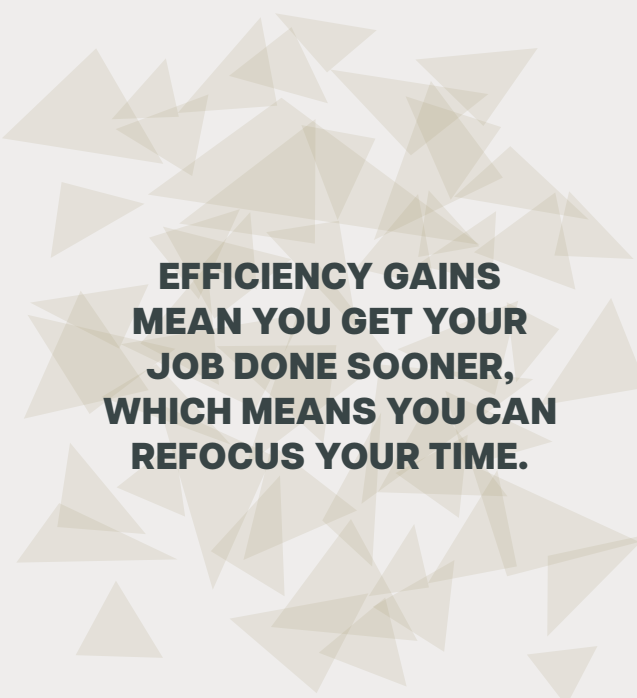
Access to global cash has also improved. What used to take hours or even days to compile is now available in real time or near real time, thanks to better connectivity and evolving platform capabilities.

"Visibility matters," highlights Verholen. "It's much easier now than before to know where your cash is."

These improvements go hand in hand with process automation across reconciliation, reporting, and forecasting, areas where the team continues to invest. Together, these operational improvements have saved staff hours, freeing up the treasury team to think more strategically and engage more deeply with the business.

"Efficiency gains mean you get your job done sooner, which means you can refocus your time," reflects Verholen. "Combine that with having more data at your fingertips, and you start seeing things you didn't have time to look at before."

Take a bank account that shows minimal activity, for example. Previously, that might have gone unnoticed. Now, armed with real-time dashboards and improved reconciliation tools, the team can engage with business units and reroute transactions more effectively.



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"You can have a discussion with the business to see why that is the case," Verholen elaborates. "Maybe those transactions can be redirected elsewhere, or maybe the account can be closed."

Better use of data is also driving improvements in cash flow forecasting, though limitations still exist here. Key inputs, such as forward-looking FX exposures, are often buried in ERP systems and, while available in theory, they can be inaccessible in practice.

"There's a lot of information that we know is out there, but we don't have immediate access to," Verholen adds. "Getting at that data will be a big unlock."

Enhancing traceability in compliance

In addition to supporting strategy, visibility also plays a crucial role in strengthening compliance. In what may shock more recent entrants to the treasury profession, Verholen recalls a time when audit processes were almost entirely manual.

"You had to physically sign a piece of paper," he says. "Auditors would come in and check whether you put the signature on the right date. It was all very ad hoc."

The shift to digital has changed that. Today, system-based controls are embedded into Zoetis' workflows, ensuring compliance with both internal policies and external requirements, such as US Sarbanes-Oxley Act (SOX) standards. This is a federal law enacted to protect investors by improving the accuracy and reliability of corporate disclosures.

"Putting that all into a system avoids the risk of a control issue," Verholen notes. "You know what you did, when you did it, and in what system. That enhances compliance by default."

The move has also reduced audit fatigue, enabling faster responses to queries and clearer documentation of actions taken. In this context, digital tools are not just time-savers, they are actively reducing risk.

Keeping an eye on AI

No discussion of treasury transformation is complete without touching on AI, which is starting to find its place in corporate treasury and the wider banking ecosystem. Rather than chasing hype, treasurers and banks are taking steps to explore how AI can support existing processes.

“Banks use AI for payment screening and exception reporting,” Verholen points out. “It’s helping them identify outliers and resolve issues faster.”

For treasurers, AI is primarily mentioned in regards to cash flow forecasting. Adopting AI in forecasting requires process and system changes that can make the adoption threshold rather high for those looking to add AI to the process quickly. But of course, the impact will be significant. Cash flow forecasting is not the only use case for AI in treasury however. At Zoetis, the technology is helping the team explain its role more clearly to the wider business.

“We all use our own lingo in treasury,” explains Verholen. “Trying to clarify what we do to someone unfamiliar with our world can be painful. But using tools such as ChatGPT to simplify that language, to write manuals or slides for a broader audience has been powerful.”

This ability to demystify treasury isn’t just a communications win. It supports change management by helping teams outside the function better understand treasury’s purpose and potential.

“If we can show what we’re seeing in terms of sales patterns, manufacturing flows, or capital spending, then we can really show our value,” highlights Verholen.

Vocal about value

For Verholen, the path ahead in the ongoing transformation across treasury at Zoetis is both familiar and unfinished. The priorities are clear: strengthen integration across systems, unlock data that is still trapped

in silos, and sharpen the team’s ability to act on insight rather than intuition.

“We’re still looking into our ERP and TMS landscape to see how we can automate further,” he enthuses. “That’s really what’s going to free up more time for analysis instead of processing.”

A key area of focus is enhancing cash flow forecasting through improved visibility into FX exposures and customer payment behaviour. Much of the relevant data already exists, but extracting it easily and in a usable format remains a work in progress.

“There’s so much happening in our ERP landscape that will help us get there,” reflects Verholen. “When are our customers paying? Where are the forecast exposures? Those are the sorts of insights we’re still working to make visible.”

At the same time, he sees a broader opportunity to connect the dots across the business and communicate treasury’s role with more clarity and confidence. As systems evolve and data becomes more accessible, treasury can be more vocal about the value it brings.

“I believe treasury is in the centre of the business,” Verholen concludes. “The better we can surface the information we already have, the more we can contribute.”

The core foundations of centralisation, automation, and visibility built over the past few years are what make that future possible. The treasury transformation at Zoetis is not just a set of completed projects. It is a platform for ongoing progress.

TREASURY TRANSFORMATION TIPS

Don’t start with technology, start with a purpose. That’s the advice from Zoetis’ Assistant Treasurer Michel Verholen, who believes lasting change in treasury begins with a clear vision rooted in real pain points.

“Very often, if you look at technology, it’s a vendor trying to sell you something,” he says. “I always first ask what the requirement is?”

Verholen cautions against waiting to construct the perfect treasury roadmap before engaging in a transformation. “If you want to wait until everything is fully defined, you’re never going to start,” he warns, instead advocating for starting small, staying flexible, and involving the team throughout the journey.

“Share as much as you can,” Verholen urges. “If you’re passionate about something, make sure people understand the benefits. Then they’ll follow your lead.”

THE PILLARS OF JOURNEYS TO TREASURY

The strength of Journeys to Treasury (JTT) has always extended beyond the report itself. Its unparalleled value lies in harnessing the collective expertise of four leading institutions—BNP Paribas, PwC, SAP, and EACT—and their global networks of specialists. For a decade, a group of senior leaders have served as its stewards, opening their organisations, shaping its strategic direction, and ensuring its insights resonate with the treasury community worldwide.

Jan Dirk van Beusekom
| BNP Paribas

Jan Dirk has placed BNP Paribas' intellectual capital at the heart of JTT, leveraging not only his strategic perspective but also the bank's deep expertise in treasury management. His leadership ensured that each edition delivered not just analysis, but actionable intelligence a hallmark of a world-leading financial institution.



François Masquelier | EACT

François amplified the voice of corporate treasurers in JTT. As Chair of the EACT, he ensured the initiative reflected the priorities and aspirations of Europe's treasury community, making JTT a unique platform where practitioners' perspectives stand alongside those of banks, consultants, and technologists.



Didier Vandenhoute | PwC

Didier embedded professional rigour into JTT, integrating PwC's advisory strengths: data analytics, diagnostics, benchmarking, and treasury transformation into every edition. Through his guidance, JTT's insights have remained grounded in real-world challenges, tested and validated by the experiences of treasurers globally.



Apoorva Dwivedi | BNP Paribas

Apoorva designed JTT's communication strategy and expansion, giving the initiative a distinctive voice and broader visibility. Convinced that JTT should transcend the page, he launched new formats: the JTT Podcast and JTT Live events across Europe transforming the initiative into a dynamic platform for dialogue, collaboration, and engagement.



Christian Mnich | SAP

Christian bridged vision with execution, bringing SAP's global innovation ecosystem to JTT. Under his stewardship, the initiative demystified emerging trends: automation, APIs, and integration, translating them into clear, practical perspectives on how technology reshapes treasury. In 2024, Christian transitioned to a new role within SAP.



Dr Arif Esa | SAP

As Global Lead for Treasury and Working Capital Management at SAP, Dr Arif Esa carries forward the firm's long-standing partnership with JTT. Having contributed to previous editions, he now takes up the editorial mantle for the 10th edition, ensuring SAP's voice of innovation remains central to the dialogue. His involvement reflects both continuity and renewal— a reaffirmation of SAP's constant and active role in shaping JTT's exploration of how technology continues to redefine treasury.



A Decade of Shared Expertise

Over nine editions, JTT has become a trusted convergence point for treasurers worldwide. Its authority stems from a rare fusion of banking, consulting, technology, and corporate voices and from the commitment of its leaders to embed their organisations' expertise into the conversation. This 10th edition stands as both a milestone and a testament not only to their individual stewardship, but to the unparalleled collaboration they have cultivated.

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PHOTO CREDIT

Shutterstock

PUBLISHER

Treasury Management International (TMI) | tmi.co

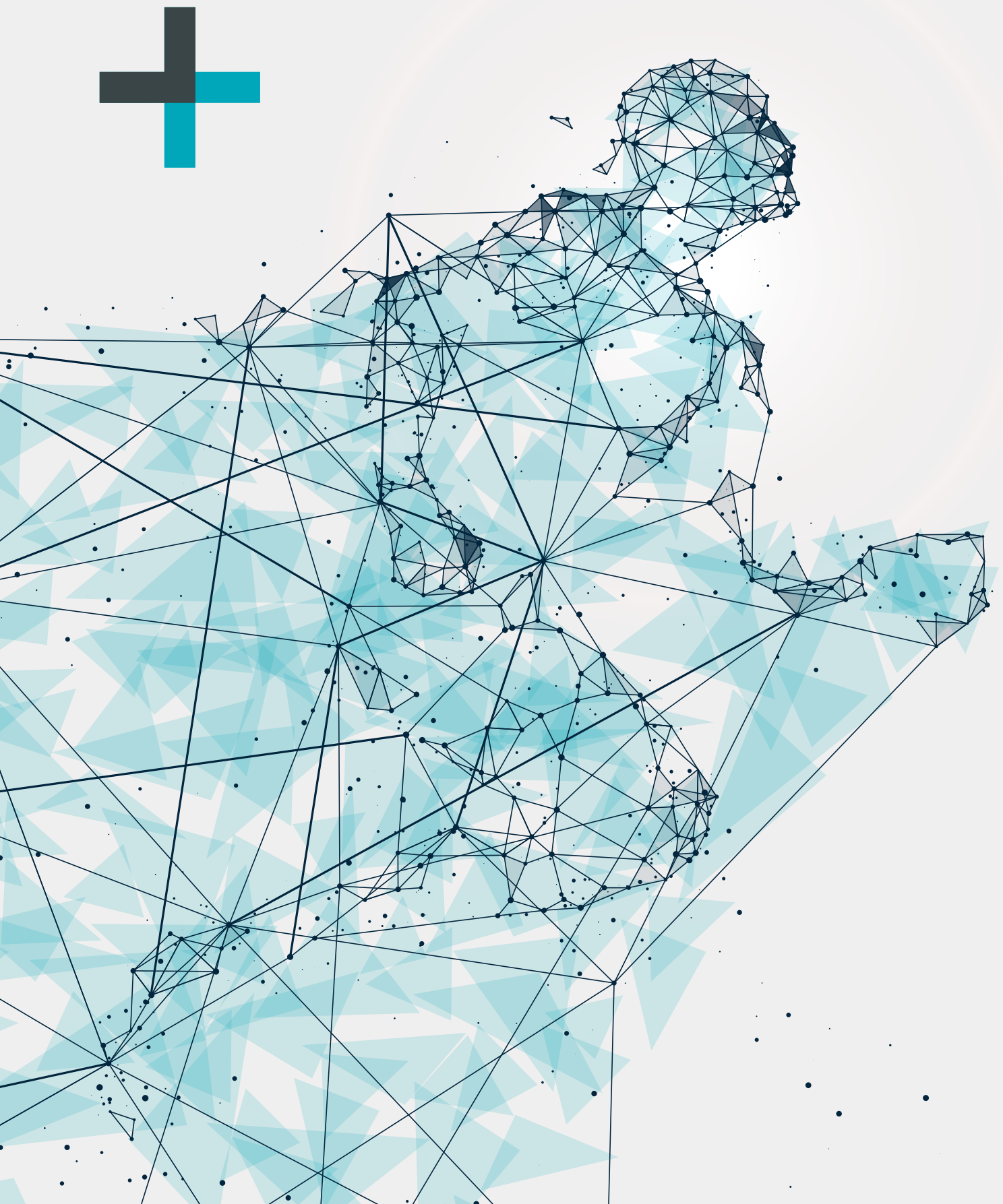
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